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Nine hospitalised after blaze erupts in residential building

NATION: PG 5
BJP-led NDA governs 80% of India: Amit Shah

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Tara Sutaria calls Toxic 'fearless, fabulous'

CNG prices hiked by Re 1, second time in a week

NEW DELHI: CNG prices were hiked by Re 1 per kg on Sunday, the second increase in rates in less than a week.

CNG now costs Rs 80.09 per kg in the national capital, according to Indraprastha Gas Ltd, the country's biggest city gas firm.

The rate hike comes within days of Rs 2 per kg increase in rates on Thursday.

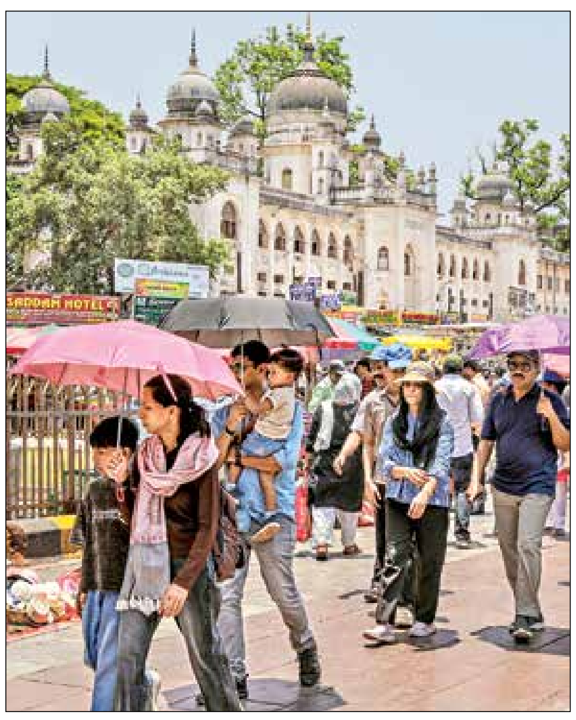
Rates of gas piped to household kitchens, called piped natural gas, however, remain unchanged.

IGL said, "The retail selling price of CNG has been increased by Re 1/kg wef 6 am on 17.05.2026 in all geographical areas (GAs) of IGL".

"The revision in retail prices of CNG has been effected only to marginally offset the impact of increase in input gas cost along with steep Continued on P4

TEMP MAY RISE FURTHER BY 3 TO 5 DEGREES CELSIUS

North India braces for intense heatwave, temp in Delhi may touch 45°C this week



People cover themselves from the scorching heat during an afternoon heatwave, at Charminar, in Hyderbad, Telangana PTI

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Temperatures across large parts of India are expected to climb sharply over the coming days, with the India Meteorological Department warning that Delhi and surrounding regions could see maximums of 45 degrees Celsius between May 18 and May 20, as another heatwave cycle takes hold over the northern and central parts of the country.

The IMD confirmed on May 17 that both daytime and nighttime temperatures were already "markedly above normal" across several states on May 16. In parts of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar and Gujarat, readings were running more than five degrees Celsius above seasonal averages. The highest temperature recorded on May 16 was 46 degrees Celsius, logged at Amraoti and Wardha in Maharashtra's Vidarbha region.

Heatwave alerts are now in place across a wide stretch of the country. The IMD said heatwave conditions are likely over some pockets of Rajasthan from May 17 to 23, and over Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh and Delhi from May 18 to 23. Madhya Pradesh and Vidarbha are expected to remain under heatwave conditions until May 21, while Chhattisgarh faces similar conditions on May 20 and 21. Telangana is under heatwave watch from May 17 to 23, and western Rajasthan may additionally see unusually warm nights on May 17 and 18.

The situation in Uttar Pradesh is being watched closely. The IMD has forecast that heatwave conditions will persist there until May 23, and warned that isolated pockets of the state Continued on P4

KEY POINTS

- Heatwave alerts issued for Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh and Delhi from May 18 to 23
- Rajasthan remains under heatwave watch from May 17 to 23
- Telangana faces heatwave conditions from May 17 to 23
- Uttar Pradesh heatwave may turn "severe" in isolated pockets from May 19 to 23
- Severe heatwave declared when temperatures cross 47°C or exceed normal by 6.4°C
- MADHYA PRADESH AND VIDARBHA UNDER HEATWAVE ALERT UNTIL MAY 21

India, Sweden agree to elevate bilateral ties to Strategic Partnership

PM Modi receives Sweden's prestigious award Royal Order of Polar Star

Prime Minister Narendra Modi being conferred with Sweden's Royal Order of Polar Star by Crown Princess Victoria, in Gothenburg ANI

MPOST BUREAU

GOTHENBURG (SWEDEN): India and Sweden took their bilateral relationship to a new level on Sunday, formalising a Strategic Partnership during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's two-day visit to Gothenburg, where the two nations signalled a shared commitment to deeper cooperation across trade, technology, defence, and green transition.

Modi, who last visited Sweden in 2018 for the first-ever India-Nordic Summit, was received at Gothenburg Airport by Swedish Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson in a personal gesture of welcome. The arrival was notable in itself, with Swedish Air Force jets escorting the Indian prime minister's aircraft as it entered Swedish airspace.

The centrepiece of the visit was delegation-level talks between the two leaders, covering the full breadth of India-Sweden relations. Ministry of External Affairs Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal confirmed that both sides agreed to elevate their bilateral relationship to a Strategic Partnership, calling it "a major milestone." Discussions covered investment, innovation, Continued on P4

Kerala: VD Satheesan announces 20-member Cabinet, oath today

MPOST BUREAU

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala's new government, led by Chief Minister-designate V D Satheesan, is set to be sworn in Monday at 10 am, with a 20-member Cabinet finalised in record time. The United Democratic Front, which swept 102 of 140 Assembly seats, completed the entire ministerial selection process within 24 hours.

The Cabinet features 14 first-time ministers, two women, and two members from the Scheduled Caste community, marking a departure from the previous government, which had no SC representation. Senior figures including Ramesh Chennithala, K Muraleedharan, and IUML's P K Kunhalikutty return to ministerial roles alongside fresh faces from Congress and alliance partners.

"After 60 years, the entire UDF cabinet is set to take the oath together," Satheesan said, calling it unprecedented in Kerala's political history. Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan will serve as Assembly Speaker, with Shanimol Usman as Deputy Speaker. National Congress leaders including Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge are expected to attend the ceremony. See P5

Fire breaks out in Delhi-bound Rajdhani Express in MP's Ratlam; no one hurt, rail traffic restored

B-1 coach of Thiruvananthapuram-Hazrat Nizamuddin Rajdhani Express on fire, in Ratlam on Sunday ANI

MPOST BUREAU

RATLAM/KOTA: A fire broke out in a coach of the Thiruvananthapuram-Hazrat Nizamuddin Rajdhani Express in Madhya Pradesh's Ratlam district in the early hours of Sunday, damaging two coaches and halting traffic on the busy Mumbai-Delhi rail corridor for over seven hours. All 68 passengers in the affected coach were evacuated safely, though five railway staffers were later injured when a vehicle carrying repair equipment overturned on its way to the site.

The train, numbered 12431, had pulled out of Ratlam Junction at around 3.45 am. The fire broke out at 5.15 am in the B-1 coach as the train passed between Vikramgarh Alot and Lunirichha stations under the Kota division, said West Central Railway Chief Public Relations Officer Harshit Shrivastava. The blaze also damaged the luggage-cum-guard van attached behind the coach. Railway authorities shut off the overhead electric supply, and the fire was brought under control. The B-1 coach was detached, and the train resumed its journey at around 9.45 am, arriving in Kota at 1.15 pm and departing again at 2.30 pm. Continued on P4

US SETS 5 CONDITIONS

Trump warns Iran: Deal or destruction

TAKEAWAYS

- Trump spoke with Netanyahu hours before the post, discussing possible renewed fighting
- US demands Iran hand over 400 kilograms of enriched uranium to Washington
- Washington wants Iran to keep only one nuclear facility active
- US refuses to release even 25% of Iran's frozen assets
- US also declines to pay war compensation and wants war ended post-negotiations
- Iran demands military operations, especially in Lebanon, stop before any talks resume
- Tehran also wants sanctions lifted, frozen assets released, and war damages compensated
- Iran demands formal recognition of its sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz

MPOST BUREAU

WASHINGTON/NEW DELHI: A fresh warning from Donald Trump has heightened tensions between Washington and Tehran as negotiations over Iran's nuclear programme and the broader regional conflict remain stalled. In a message posted on Truth Social on Sunday, Trump said, "For Iran, the Clock is ticking, and they better get moving, FAST, or there won't be anything left of them. TIME IS OF THE ESSENCE." The statement came at a time when both sides continue to disagree on key demands related to uranium stockpiles, sanctions relief and compensation linked to months of fighting across the Middle East.

The warning followed a phone call between Trump and Benjamin Netanyahu, during which the two leaders discussed the possibility of renewed military action against Iran. Israeli media reports said Trump also briefed Netanyahu on his recent visit to China. The exchange highlights growing concern in Washington and Tel Aviv that diplomacy may fail to resolve the crisis.

Details of the US proposal have emerged through Iran's semi-official Fars Continued on P4

'OUTBREAK IS SERIOUS BUT NOT A PANDEMIC LIKE COVID-19'

WHO declares global health emergency over Ebola disease outbreak in Congo and Uganda

ASSOCIATED PRESS

ABUJA (NIGERIA): WHO Director-General Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus declared the Ebola disease outbreak in Congo and neighboring Uganda a public health emergency of international concern on Sunday after more than 300 suspected cases and 88 deaths.

In a post on X, the World Health Organization said the outbreak does not meet the criteria of a pandemic emergency like the COVID-19 pandemic, and advised against the closure of international borders.

WHO said a laboratory-confirmed case has also been reported in Congo's capital of Kinshasa, which is about 1,000 kilometres Continued on P4

HIGHLIGHTS

- Over 300 suspected cases and 88 deaths reported in Congo and Uganda
- Current outbreak caused by rare Bundibugyo Ebola strain
- No approved vaccines or treatments exist for Bundibugyo variant
- High positivity rates suggest outbreak larger than reported
- Conflict, migration, and mining activity complicate containment efforts
- Outbreak likely began in April; index case still unknown

Gang rape, blackmail, silence: Two sisters dead as Jodhpur police face negligence claims

MPOST BUREAU

JODHPUR: Two sisters in Rajasthan's Jodhpur district have died by suicide within two months, with allegations that police failed to act against men accused of sexually assaulting and blackmailing them. The younger woman died on May 15 after repeatedly seeking action from authorities over her sister's death on March 20, triggering protests, detentions of suspects, and a departmental inquiry into police conduct.

Police said the younger woman's death on Friday led to large protests outside Mathuradas Mathur Hospital, where her body was taken. Members of the local community, including the Rajput group, gathered to demand arrests and accountability, accusing officials of inaction. The victims' father also called for an impartial investigation and strict punishment for those involved. Continued on P4

SHAHDARA AREA

Nine hospitalised after blaze erupts in residential building

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Nine people, including women and a minor girl, were hospitalised with breathing difficulties after they were rescued from a fire at a four-storey residential building in Delhi's Shahdara area on Sunday, officials said.

According to the Delhi Fire Services (DFS), they received a call at 12.03 am informing about the blaze at D-45 in Mansarover Park. Three fire tenders and a water bowser were rushed to the spot.

Subsequently, nine nine people trapped on different floors of the building were rescued and shifted to the Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital after they complained of breathing difficulties caused by smoke inhalation.

The injured were identified as Vanshika (20), Tanishka Soni (19), Durgesh (49), Yogesh Verma (50), Raj Rani (65), Arun Garg (48), Ananya (12), Renu Garg (19), and Prateek Garg (19).

The fire was later brought under control, officials said.

According to a senior DFS official, the fire had erupted in the domestic articles kept at the ground floor parking lot of the building.

> **The fire, caused by a short circuit in a motor, broke out in the parking area of the building and remained confined there**

Meanwhile, Mansarover Park Police said the fire was likely caused by a short circuit in a motor.

"The fire, reportedly caused by a short circuit in a motor, broke out in the parking area of the building and remained confined there," read the police statement.

Police and DFS teams responded promptly, extinguished the fire, and safely rescued nine residents from the upper floors.

"All the rescued persons were shifted to GTB Hospital as they complained of breathing difficulties due to smoke inhalation. They were treated and subsequently discharged. No casualties or burn injuries were reported," the statement read.

Several videos of the rescue work by police and DFS has gone viral on social media platforms.

Delhi Police asks personnel to use public transport following PM's save fuel appeal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Following Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to curb fuel consumption and avoid unnecessary expenditure, Delhi Police has instructed its personnel — especially those stationed at the Police Headquarters and offices linked by Metro connectivity — to use public transport for routine travel, an official said.

The General Administration Branch (GAB) of Delhi Police Headquarters, acting with the approval of senior officers, has issued a 13-point directive aimed at cutting avoidable vehicular movement, conserving electricity and promoting economical use of government resources across all districts.

According to the order, staff posted in offices having Metro and public transport connectivity, especially at PHQ, have been encouraged to use public transport for daily commuting.

CLOSER LOOK

- » Staff posted in offices having Metro and public transport connectivity, especially at PHQ, have been encouraged to use public transport for daily commuting, order states
- » Investigating officers and other staff travelling from the same police station, subdivision or unit to common destinations have been directed to use pooled vehicles

"Staff posted in offices having Metro/public transport connectivity, particularly at PHQ, shall be encouraged to use public transport for routine commuting whenever operationally feasible," read the memorandum, issued by Deputy Commissioner of Police (GAB) Aalap Patel.

To minimise unnecessary fuel consumption and optimise vehicle usage, the circular directed the pooling of dak motorcycles and other two-wheelers at police stations and units. Investigating officers and other staff travelling from the same police station, subdivision or unit to common destinations have been directed to use pooled vehicles as far as practicable. It also directed that routine meetings, reviews, coordination conferences and inter-unit consultations be conducted via virtual platforms.

The order further emphasises proper upkeep and fuel-efficient maintenance of all official vehicles. Units have been instructed to ensure timely servicing, maintenance of tyre pressure, proper engine tuning, replacement of worn-out parts and periodic inspection of fuel systems.

Supervisory officers have also been asked to ensure that vehicles due for servicing are not overused and that avoidable fuel wastage is prevented through better maintenance practices. In another significant instruction, security units have been directed to rationalise the size of VIP and VVIP convoys, ensuring minimum essential deployment of vehicles.

"Security units shall ensure minimum essential deployment of vehicles in VIP/VVIP movement, without compromising security, protocols, or operational requirements," it read. District Deputy Commissioners of Police and unit heads have also been asked to periodically monitor fuel consumption, maintain vehicle logbooks and review utilisation patterns to ensure economical and need-based deployment.

According to the order, any abnormal fuel consumption is to be examined immediately. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Labourer dies of electrocution near Punjabi Bagh park

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old labourer died after allegedly suffering an electric shock from an iron railing at a park in west Delhi's Punjabi Bagh area, police said on Sunday.

The deceased, Rohit, a resident of Rajiv Gandhi Camp, had gone to drink water from a tap near the wall of a park when the incident took place, they said.

"During the process, he allegedly came in contact with an electrified iron railing and suffered a severe electric shock," the officer said.

Police said Rohit collapsed and was rushed for medical assistance, where doctors declared him dead.

A case has been registered at Punjabi Bagh police station and an investigation has been initiated, the officer said.

Police are probing how the railing became electrically charged and whether there was any leakage of current from nearby wiring or electrical infrastructure in the park area.

Investigators are also examining whether negligence in maintenance of electrical fittings or illegal wiring could have led to the incident, police said.

The spot was inspected by police and technical teams, and authorities are expected to examine the electrical connections installed near the park and water tap, they said.

The exact cause of the electrocution will be ascertained after technical examination and further investigation, they said. MPOST

Delhi University & St Stephen's clash over principal post

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: A fresh dispute has emerged between the University of Delhi (DU) and St. Stephen's College after the university directed the college to halt the appointment process of Professor Susan Elias as principal, citing alleged violations of University Grants Commission (UGC) regulations.

The controversy began after St. Stephen's College announced that Prof. Elias would assume office as principal from June 1, 2026. The appointment was being viewed as historic, as she would become the first woman principal in the institution's 145-year history.

However, DU objected to the selection process, claiming that the committee constituted for the appointment did not comply with UGC Regulations, 2018. According to the university, DU nominees and required subject experts were not included in the panel, rendering the committee improperly constituted.

DU asked St Stephen's to halt the appointment process and form a fresh panel under UGC norms, while the college defended its procedure as lawful.

The dispute adds to recent disagreements between the university and the college over admissions, reservations and administrative powers.

Man dies after consuming poisonous substance: Cops

NEW DELHI: A 34-year-old man died after allegedly consuming a poisonous substance in the Rani Bagh area here, police said on Sunday.

The incident came to light when Head Constable Rambir and Constable Amar, who were on routine patrolling duty near the Ramada Hotel on the carriageway towards Deepali Chowk, were signalled by a man standing outside a car, police said.

The patrolling staff found the man in a heavily intoxicated condition and unfit to drive safely. "Showing promptness, they brought him to the Rani Bagh Police Station for assistance and safety measures," a police officer said.

At the police station, the man informed the duty officer that he had consumed a poisonous substance commonly used as a pesticide.

Realising the seriousness of the situation, police immediately shifted him to Bhagwan Mahavir Hospital in Pitampura, where he was identified as Brijkesh Dutt Mishra, a resident of Rohini Sector-4.

Despite medical intervention, doctors declared him dead during treatment, police said. MPOST

Immigration consultant held for cheating woman via fake Canada business scheme

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Cyber Cell of Delhi Police's Crime Branch has arrested an alleged immigration consultant for allegedly cheating a woman on the false promise of securing Canadian immigration through a business investment programme.

Police said they were alerted to the matter through a complaint registered at the Cyber Police Station of the Crime Branch. The accused, identified as Dharminder Sharma, was arrested in connection with an FIR lodged under Sections 420, 409 and 120B of the Indian Penal Code.

According to investigators, Sharma allegedly duped the complainant of around CAD 2,95,000 after claiming he could facilitate her immigration to Canada in the aftermath of the first wave of the COVID-19 pandemic, when she was seeking better employment opportunities abroad.

> Sharma allegedly duped the complainant of around CAD 2,95,000 after claiming he could facilitate her immigration to Canada

Police said Sharma introduced himself as the Director (Operations) of an immigration consultancy firm and portrayed himself as an expert in Canadian immigration and overseas investment programmes.

The complainant was allegedly persuaded to invest CAD 2,50,000 in a purported business investment scheme and pay an additional CAD 45,000 as professional fees. In return, Sharma allegedly promised Canadian immigration, work permits and business ownership rights. During the investigation, police found that Sharma had allegedly prepared documents falsely showing that the complainant would become a director and shareholder in a Canada-based hospitality company. However, officials said the probe revealed that her name never appeared in the company's incorporation records and that ownership remained with other individuals.

Investigators further alleged that after receiving the money in foreign bank accounts, Sharma siphoned off the funds through cash withdrawals, debit transactions and transfers across multiple accounts instead of using them for legitimate business purposes.

Police alleged that even after Canadian authorities rejected the complainant's visa applications three times, the accused continued to mislead her to delay repayment. A laptop containing alleged digital evidence, including emails, financial records and immigration documents, was recovered. The investigation was conducted by a team led by Inspector Vinay Kumar.

Couple nabbed for Rs 1L theft from senior citizen

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested a couple for allegedly stealing cash from a 60-year-old man while he was travelling in an e-rickshaw in West Delhi, officials said.

Police said the case came to light after a complaint was registered at Moti Nagar Police Station. The complainant, a resident of Kirti Nagar, alleged that he had hired an e-rickshaw from near the Jaguar showroom on Shivaji Marg in Moti Nagar to Fun Cinema Red Light on May 13 while carrying a small bag containing Rs 1 lakh in cash. After reaching his destination, he found that the bag had been slit open and the money was missing.

Following the complaint, an e-FIR was registered under Section 303(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and an investigation was launched.

A special team led by SHO Inspector Sunil Kumar and the ACP of Punjabi Bagh Sub-Division analysed CCTV footage from the route taken by the complainant and identified the e-rickshaw allegedly used in the offence.

During the investigation, the accused, identified as 25-year-old Suresh and his wife, were apprehended through technical surveillance and sustained tracking efforts. Police said the couple allegedly targeted elderly passengers travelling in e-rickshaws and stole cash and valuables during transit without raising suspicion.

Officials said Rs 90,000 in stolen cash and the e-rickshaw used in the crime were recovered. MPOST

Chemists seek clear guidelines after fake medicine rackets busted

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Local pharmacists across Delhi have expressed growing concern after two counterfeit medicine rackets were recently busted by Delhi Police, urging the government to issue clear guidelines to help chemists distinguish between fake and genuine medicines in the market.

Pharmacists said the recent crackdowns have created panic among retailers and distributors, as even reputed suppliers and experienced chemists were allegedly unable to identify counterfeit medicines. They warned that the circulation of fake drugs could pose a serious public health threat if authorities fail to introduce proper verification systems and awareness programmes for those involved in the pharmaceutical supply chain.

Several chemists also raised concerns regarding low-cost medicines distributed under government schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Jan Aushadhi Yojana. While some retailers questioned the authenticity of medicines sold at significantly lower prices, certified pharmacists clarified that cheaper medicines are not necessarily fake or ineffective.

A representative of Amrit Medicos said pharmacists and customers often become suspicious when medicines priced at around Rs 1,000 in regular markets are available for nearly Rs 100 under government schemes. The representative urged authorities to introduce an official verification mechanism for chemists.

Representatives from Vaishisht Medical and Shivam Medicos also called for awareness sessions and training programmes to help pharmacists identify counterfeit medicines and reassure consumers.

However, pharmaceutical professionals rejected claims that Jan Aushadhi medicines are fake, stating that such generic medicines are approved by regulatory authorities and supplied through authorised channels. They said lower prices are due to generic formulations and government subsidies. Chemists have now urged regulators to conduct regular inspections and awareness drives to safeguard public health.

HOSPITAL, NURSING HOME LAND UP FOR ALLOTMENT

Noida Authority rolls out industrial, institutional and hotel plot schemes

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: The Noida Authority has launched multiple industrial, institutional and commercial plot schemes simultaneously, offering plots for industries, hospitals, nursing homes, schools, corporate offices and hotels across various sectors of the city.

Officials said applications for the schemes will open from May 19, while earnest money deposit (EMD) can be submitted till 5 pm on June 9. Applications will be accepted till June 11, after which allotments will be made through e-auction or interview, depending on the category. Plots will be allotted to bidders offering prices above the reserve price.

According to the authority, a total of 19 industrial plots have been launched for manufacturing and processing units. These plots range from 115 sqm to 7,997 sqm and are located in sectors 3, 6, 7, 9, 10, HC, 164, 80, Phase-2, 162 and 67. The reserve price of these plots ranges between Rs 65 lakh and Rs 18 crore.

> **For schools, two plots measuring around 18,000 sqm have been offered in Sector 19 with reserve price of Rs 143 cr**

Noida Authority CEO Krishna Karunesh said the authority has rolled out schemes across several departments and interested applicants can participate as per eligibility criteria. Under the institutional category, plots have been earmarked for schools, hospitals, nursing homes and corporate offices.

For schools, two plots measuring around 18,000 sqm have been offered in Sector 19 with a reserve price of Rs 143 crore, while another 5,000 sqm plot in Sector 42 has a reserve price of around Rs 21 crore. These plots will be allotted through an interview process.

For hospitals, plots measuring 10,000 sqm each have been launched in sectors 117 and 145. Their allotment will also be conducted through interviews. Two nursing home plots measuring around 1,000 sqm each have been launched in sectors 47 and 41, and will be allotted through e-auction. Two hotel plots have also been reserved for corporate offices.

The authority has also launched a commercial builder plot scheme, including hotel projects. Three large commercial plots measuring over 20,000 sqm have been offered in sectors 18, 96 and 93B. These plots range from 29,000 sqm to 37,000 sqm in size.

Additionally, two commercial plots below 20,000 sqm are available in sectors 94 and 18. Three hotel plots have also been launched in sectors 71, 124 and 142, ranging between 7,500 sqm and 12,570 sqm. These plots will be allotted through e-auction.

Noida plans paperless governance

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: In a major step towards digital governance, the Noida Authority is preparing to make its entire functioning paperless by integrating all departmental records and files into a unified online platform.

The move comes in view of the rapidly expanding urban infrastructure and the growing number of property-related matters in the city. Once implemented, officials will no longer need to search through files across multiple departments to access information related to a property. By entering a property number, complete details of the allottee and NOC-related approvals will be available instantly on a mobile phone or computer screen.

Officials said the integrated digital system is aimed at increasing transparency, improving coordination among departments and speeding up public services.

> 'Digital platform will significantly reduce delays caused by missing files...'

According to the authority, the existing manual file system will gradually be phased out. An integrated online platform is being developed to connect all current software systems and departmental databases under a single digital framework.

Under the new arrangement, departments including building plan approval, water, sewer, electricity and NOC-related sections will be linked to the same system. If an allottee gets a building map approved and later applies for water connection, sewer clearance or other permissions, officials will not have to call for separate files from different departments.

Instead, officers will be able to log into the server, enter the property number and instantly access the complete record of the allottee. The system will display building plan approvals, payment status, application progress and all departmental permissions on one screen.

The authority believes the digital platform will significantly reduce delays caused by missing files, manual verification and lack of inter-departmental coordination. It will also improve record security and make tracking of applications easier.

Officials said a presentation of the integrated software was recently made before the Authority CEO, during which several technical and operational suggestions were discussed.

Officials said the phased paperless system will improve transparency, accountability and efficiency while reducing delays and paperwork for residents.

10-year-old boy drowns in pvt swimming pool

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 10-year-old boy drowned in a private swimming pool in north Delhi's Jagatpur area on Sunday, with family members alleging negligence and absence of safety measures at the facility.

The victim, identified as Sanskaar, had gone to the pool with his brother and friends when he was allegedly found unconscious in the water nearly half an hour later. He was rushed to a hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

Family members alleged that no lifeguards or life jackets were present and claimed nobody noticed the child drowning for several minutes. Police said the pool was found unguarded and a case has been registered. Legal action against the pool owner is underway.

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LABOUR DEPT OFFERS ASSISTANCE TO PRIVATE ORGANISATIONS

Fuel-saving push: Delhi bats for WFH in pvt sector, carpooling...

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has advised private companies and organisations to adopt a two-day work-from-home policy, make changes to office timings, and urge employees to avail car pooling and public transport to support the fuel-saving efforts amid global uncertainties.

Private entities involved in essential, emergency services like hospitals and other health establishments, electricity, water, sanitation and related municipal services, were not covered by the advisory issued by the Delhi labour department.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta earlier this week launched the 90-day 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' fuel-saving campaign, stipulating two-day work-from-home for all Delhi government employees, and use of public transport.

She had said the private sector too will be urged to support these fuel-saving initiatives in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal on wise expenditure of resources.

The labour department advisory issued Sunday said in the background of the prevailing global situation, it is imperative to conserve fuel —petrol, diesel and CNG — and ensure its optimal use.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Private entities involved in essential, emergency services like hospitals and other health establishments, electricity, water, sanitation and related municipal services, were not covered by the advisory issued by the Delhi labour department
- » Chief Minister Rekha Gupta earlier this week launched the 90-day 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' fuel-saving campaign, stipulating two-day work-from-home for all Delhi govt employees, and use of public transport
- » She had said the private sector too will be urged to support these fuel-saving initiatives in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal on wise expenditure of resources

Commuting to and from offices is one of the largest contributors to daily vehicular fuel consumption in the capital, it noted. A large proportion of this fuel use can be avoided through adoption of work-from-home (WFH) arrangements, which have demonstrated its operational feasibility during COVID-19 and GRAP-related curbs, it said.

"In order to contribute to national fuel conservation efforts, all employers of industrial establishments, factories, shops and commercial establishments in Delhi, including IT, IT Enabled Services (ITES), among others are strongly encouraged to implement a minimum of two days of work-from-home per week," the advisory said.

The advisory also suggested implementing staggered working hours to reduce peak-hour vehicular load on roads, encourage employees to use public transport, car-pooling, or non-motorised modes of commute. Conversion of physical meetings to virtual or online sessions to reduce travel expenses, minimal use of official vehicles for non-essential travel, and adequate IT infrastructure support to enable seamless WFH operations were also advised.

The private sector has also been advised to take a pledge to reduce consumption of petrol, diesel and CNG through conscious commuting choices and purchase Indian-made products to strengthen the domestic economy.

"Employers are requested to sensitize their workforce about the national importance of fuel conservation during the current crisis and to actively motivate employees to adopt fuel-saving commuting practices," the advisory said.

The private organisations have been urged to contact the labour department for any assistance or clarification.

Women startups and SHGs to get collateral-free loans

AIMAN FATIMA

> We have made arrangements for collateral-free loans up to Rs 10 crore for women self-help groups and startups, for which the Delhi govt itself will act as guarantor
>
> — CM REKHA GUPTA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced collateral-free loans of up to Rs 10 crore for women-led startups and self-help groups (SHGs), saying the Delhi government itself would act as guarantor to promote women entrepreneurship and indigenous products. Launching the two-day Mega SHG Mela-2026 near Rohini West Metro Station, the Chief Minister said the initiative was aimed at making every woman in the capital financially independent while strengthening the "Vocal for Local" movement.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta said, "The Delhi Government is working on a large scale to make women self-reliant, entrepreneurial and economically empowered." She added, "We have made arrangements for collateral-free loans up to Rs 10 crore for women self-help groups and startups, for which the Delhi government itself will act as guarantor."

The mela, organised by the North-West District Administration, saw participation from around 24 self-help groups showcasing handicrafts, crochet work, khadi products, food items and household goods under the "One District, One Product" initiative. MP Yogendra Chandolia, MLA Kulwant Rana and senior district officials were also present at the event.

Highlighting Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "Atmanirbhar Bharat" and "Vocal for Local", Gupta said Indian handmade products were "second to none in quality" and needed stronger branding and marketing support. "People often run after foreign brands, whereas products made by our women are equally good. They deserve national and international recognition," she said.

The Chief Minister also announced that local products made by women entrepreneurs would be given regular platforms in malls and large shopping complexes across Delhi to help them reach larger markets.

Linking the initiative with sustainability campaigns, Gupta said the Delhi Government was also promoting "Monday Metro" and "No Vehicle Day" in response to the Prime Minister's appeal for fuel conservation and greater use of public transport and indigenous goods.

DDA's Narela flats see near sellout

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority has announced that only a limited number of 2 BHK and 3 BHK flats remain available under its "Karmayogi Awas Yojana" in Narela, targeted at serving and retired government employees and other public sector workers. According to details shared by the DDA, all 1 BHK flats under the scheme have already been sold out. The remaining housing units are being offered on a first-come, first-served basis, with applications open until May 31, 2026. MPOST

NDMC adds Jor Bagh to 'Anupam Colony' drive

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Sunday declared Jor Bagh as its next "Anupam Colony" under its sustainable waste management initiative aimed at promoting decentralised solid waste practices and community participation.

The announcement was made by NDMC Vice-Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal during a plantation drive organised under the "#EkPedMaaKeNaam_OnSunday" campaign in the residential colony. Residents, RWAs, senior citizens and NDMC officials participated in the event by planting saplings in the name of their mothers.

Speaking on the occasion, Chahal said the "Anupam Colony" initiative focuses on 100 per cent waste segregation at source, on-site composting, recycling and decentralised waste management to create cleaner and greener residential neighbourhoods. He said the initiative also encourages greater citizen participation and reduces waste transportation costs.

With the inclusion of Jor Bagh, colonies such as Satya Sadan Officers Flats, Bharti Nagar, Aradhana Colony, Bapu Dham Colony, New Moti Bagh and Kaka Nagar have already been developed under the model.

Calling the plantation campaign a "mass movement of emotional and social responsibility", Chahal said NDMC had prepared a year-long Green Calendar under which plantation drives would be held every Sunday across New Delhi. Departments including horticulture, sanitation, roads, drainage and water supply would jointly monitor the upkeep of saplings, he added.

The campaign, inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" initiative, seeks to link environmental conservation with public participation and civic responsibility.

CM pumps Rs 100 cr into Dwarka projects

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday launched a series of infrastructure and civic development projects worth nearly Rs 100 crore in the Dwarka Assembly constituency, promising faster urban transformation and improved basic amenities for residents. The projects, ranging from road repairs and drainage upgrades to sewer expansion and electricity infrastructure, are aimed at addressing long-pending civic issues in the rapidly growing area.

Launching the projects during a public programme in Dwarka, the Chief Minister said the Delhi Government was working to turn the vision of a "Viksit Delhi" into reality under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. "Our government's goal is not limited to announcing large schemes. We want basic facilities to reach every colony, every locality and every citizen effectively," Gupta said. She added that for the first time, such a large-scale budget allocation had been made for development works across Delhi. "Development projects worth around Rs 100 crore have been launched in Dwarka, and additional special budget has also been allocated for various works in the area," she said.

The Chief Minister also highlighted a major metro expansion project planned for the region. According to Gupta, Dwarka will benefit from a new metro project worth Rs 6,200 crore under Metro Phase-5 expansion. "Previous governments failed to provide even their share for metro projects on time, which slowed development. Our government has already released Rs 10,000 crore for metro expansion and accelerated work," she said.

MP Kamaljeet Sehrawat, MLA Pradyumn Rajput, senior officials and local residents attended the programme.

METRO FREQUENCY RAISED AMID FUEL-SAVING DRIVE

DMRC adds trains to save fuel

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push towards sustainable urban mobility and fuel conservation, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has announced that it will operate additional train trips across its network to encourage more commuters to use metro services instead of private vehicles. The move comes amid growing emphasis on reducing fuel dependency, improving environmental sustainability and strengthening public transport infrastructure across Delhi-NCR.

According to DMRC, 24 additional train trips using six extra trains will be introduced every Monday starting from May 18, 2026. The corporation said the decision was taken in anticipation of increased passenger demand due to ongoing campaigns promoting public transport and fuel conservation. "Recognizing the critical role of mass transit in ensuring energy security, economic resilience, and environmental sustainability, DMRC is undertaking a series of strategic initiatives to facilitate greater adoption of metro services," the corporation stated.

DMRC said it would closely monitor passenger flow and add more trips on other days if required. To manage the expected increase in footfall, the metro operator has also strengthened security and passenger facilitation measures across stations. "Additional security personnel, ticketing counters, baggage scanners and frisking points are being deployed to ensure smoother passenger movement during peak periods," the statement said. Highlighting Delhi Metro's role as an integrated mobility network, DMRC said its connectivity with railway stations, ISBTs, airport terminals, the Namo Bharat Regional Rapid Transit System, Noida Metro and Rapid Metro significantly reduces dependence on private vehicles and petroleum-based transport. It added that the network ensures direct access to commercial hubs, government offices, educational institutions, markets and tourist destinations across Delhi-NCR.

The corporation also underlined its focus on last-mile connectivity. Around 1 lakh passengers daily currently use services such as e-autos, e-rickshaws, bike taxis, bicycle rentals and cab aggregators available at nearly 160 metro stations. "DMRC's wide network ensures safe, reliable and swift connectivity to major commercial marketplaces, government ministries, corporate offices and educational institutions," the release said.

Recently, DMRC, with support from Indian Oil Corporation Limited, launched hydrogen-powered bus services in the Central Vista area to improve last-mile travel from metro stations. Additionally, around 1,500 Devi buses operated by Delhi Transport Corporation are currently providing feeder connectivity at 52 metro stations.

DMRC also highlighted its digital ticketing initiatives, including QR code tickets, WhatsApp ticketing, NCMC cards and integration with platforms such as Paytm, PhonePe, Amazon and IRCTC, saying these measures aim to reduce queues and make metro travel more seamless for commuters.

Trump warns Iran: Deal or destruction

Continued from Page 1

News Agency. According to the report, Washington has outlined a five-point framework that includes transferring around 400 kilograms of enriched uranium to the United States, limiting Iran to a single operational nuclear facility and dropping demands for compensation for wartime damage. The proposal also states that most of Iran's frozen overseas assets would remain blocked and that any end to the war would come only after negotiations conclude.

Iran has rejected these terms and set out its own conditions for returning to talks. Tehran has called for an immediate end to military operations across the region, including in Lebanon, and has demanded that sanctions be lifted and its frozen assets released. It has also insisted on compensation for damages caused during the conflict and recognition of its sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz, a critical route for global oil shipments.

The strategic waterway has become a focal point of the standoff. Iran has tightened control over shipping movements through the strait, while the United States has increased pressure through a naval blockade targeting Iranian ports and maritime trade. These developments have contributed to disruptions in global energy supply, pushing up oil prices and affecting international markets.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian has accused the US and Israel of attempting to destabilise Iran through the conflict. Speaking during a meeting with Pakistan's interior minister, Mohsin Naqvi, Pezeshkian said the effort aimed to create internal insecurity by supporting militant groups. He added that the plan failed because neighbouring countries refused to allow their territories to be used for attacks against Iran. He also expressed appreciation to Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iraq for their stance during the conflict.

The current deadlock comes more than a month after a ceasefire was reached in April through mediation by Pakistan. While the truce halted large-scale fighting, it has not led to a lasting political settlement. Trump has said previously that the ceasefire was agreed to at Pakistan's request and indicated that further military escalation had been avoided for that reason.Despite the pause in direct confrontation, talks have remained frozen since last week after both sides rejected each other's latest proposals. Officials familiar with the negotiations have indicated that while the US administration is seeking a deal to end the conflict, Iran's refusal to scale back its nuclear programme has raised the possibility of military options being reconsidered.

The prolonged conflict has also placed pressure on the US economy, with rising energy costs becoming a concern ahead of the November midterm elections. As diplomatic efforts continue without progress, the situation remains uncertain, with both sides holding firm on their positions and the risk of renewed escalation still present.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Odisha: Girl seeks to lodge complaint, faints after police officer threatens her

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BARIPADA: A 15-year-old girl fainted after a police officer in Odisha's Mayurbhanj district allegedly threatened her with a seven-year jail term if the harassment complaint she wanted to lodge turned out to be false, officials said on Sunday.

The Opposition BJD demanded action against the officer accusing him of subjecting her mental harassment inside the Morada Police Station on Saturday. The 15-year-old girl is now admitted to a hospital, while an FIR was registered against the man who allegedly proposed to her repeatedly, subjecting her to mental harassment.

The family also lodged a complaint against the inspector in charge (IIC) of Morada Police Station and sought the Mayurbhanj SP's intervention into the matter. The IIC was not available for comment.

When the girl, accompanied by her mother, went to police station, the IIC allegedly asked unrelated questions and further harassed her instead of accepting her complaint.

Later the family members approached Betnoti SDPO Minati Biswal over the phone and requested her to register the FIR.

On direction of the SDPO, Morada Police Station IIC Sumeet Soran register the FIR, but allegedly threatened the girl of imprisonment if she made any false complaint.

"How did the police know that the complaint was false? The officer was angry after his senior intervened. Our daughter was threatened with a seven-year jail term and asked to withdraw the complaint when her statement was being recorded," her mother said. Soon after leaving the police station, the girl who recently passed class 10 examination, collapsed and lost consciousness. She was taken to a local hospital in an unconscious state and later shifted to to district headquarters hospital in Baripada for further treatment when her condition did not improve, officials said.

Veteran Tamil film producer Rajan dies after jumping into Adyar River

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: Veteran Tamil film producer K Rajan died after jumping into the Adyar River in the city on Sunday, police said.

Police said it appears to be a case of suicide, though the reason for his extreme step was not immediately known.

The 85-year-old film personality asked his driver to stop the car while crossing the Adyar bridge and suddenly got out and jumped into the river, police sources said.

The driver immediately alerted Fire and Rescue Services personnel, who reached the spot, recovered the body, and sent it for post-mortem.

Police have registered a case, and further investigation is underway.

Rajan entered the Tamil film industry as a producer in the early 1980s. Apart from producing films, he also directed a few movies.

He also served as president of a film distributors' association.

Top leaders of political parties, including the two Dravidian majors—the DMK and AIADMK—expressed shock and grief over his death and conveyed their condolences to the bereaved family.

> The 85-year-old film personality asked his driver to stop the car while crossing the Adyar bridge and suddenly got out and jumped into the river, police sources said

Former Chief Minister and DMK President M K Stalin said Rajan had always boldly raised his voice for the welfare of small film producers and the overall development of the film industry.

"He had always urged that Tamil films be titled in Tamil," Stalin said in a statement, adding that Rajan consistently fought for the rights of ordinary workers in the film industry.

AIADMK general secretary and former Chief Minister Edappadi K Palaniswami said Rajan's voice was important in securing recognition for small-budget films in the Tamil film industry.

Among others who condoled his death was PMK founder S Ramadoss. Leaders from various parties also expressed their condolences to the bereaved family.

"This is terrible news. Deeply shocked to hear about the demise of our beloved member of the film fraternity, producer K Rajan sir," actor and BJP leader Khushbu Sundar said in a post on social media platform X.

"He was a very respectful person and someone who never hesitated to call a spade a spade. This is very upsetting. May his soul rest in peace," she added.

Indian killed in drone attack in Moscow region

MOSCOW/NEW DELHI: An Indian worker was killed and three others were injured in a drone attack in the Moscow region, the Indian embassy in Russia said Sunday.

Russian media reported that three people were killed and another six suffered injuries in the Moscow region in the Ukrainian drone attack on Saturday night. It did not identify the nationalities of the deceased.

The incident comes amid escalating hostilities between Russia and Ukraine.

Ukraine carried out overnight attacks targeting several installations in the Moscow region.

"One Indian worker has lost his life and three others have been injured in a drone attack in Moscow region earlier today. Embassy officials have visited the location and met the injured workers in the hospital," the Indian Embassy in Russia said on 'X'.

"The Embassy condoles the loss of life and is working with the company management and local authorities to provide necessary assistance to the workers," it said, even though it did not disclose the identities of the deceased or the injured.

In a social media post, the Russian embassy in New Delhi mourned the death of the Indian. "The Russian Embassy mourns together with the family of the Indian worker and extends its sympathy to those injured by the Ukrainian attack on civilian facilities in the Moscow region," it said.

"According to preliminary reports, more than 12 people were injured in the city of Moscow, while in the Moscow region three people were killed and another six were injured," it added.

AGENCIES

Central approval delays portfolio allocation for newly inducted Uttar Pradesh ministers

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The allocation of portfolios to ministers inducted and promoted in the Uttar Pradesh Cabinet last week has been delayed due to pending approval from the BJP's central leadership, sources said.

According to party insiders, the state leadership is yet to receive clearance from the Centre on the proposed distribution of departments, resulting in uncertainty over the final allocation of portfolios.

The matter is now expected to be resolved only after Prime Minister Narendra Modi returns from his foreign visit on May 20.

Sources said consultations between the Uttar Pradesh leadership and the party high command are continuing, but consensus has not been reached on some key departments.

The delay has also stalled appointments to vacant posts in state corporations and boards, besides holding back the announcement of the BJP's new Uttar Pradesh state team.

Another round of discussions is likely on Monday in Raipur where Union Home minister Amit Shah and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath are expected to attend the meeting of the Central Zonal Council.

Chief ministers of Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh will also participate in the meeting.

The Cabinet expansion took place on May 10 and portfolio allocation was expected soon after Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's meetings with Amit Shah and BJP national president J P Nadda in Delhi.

However, sources said the final approval from the central leadership is still awaited.

Party insiders said lists for appointments to corporations and boards, including names for ministers of state with rank, had already been prepared. The BJP leadership had planned to announce these appointments along with the new state team immediately after the cabinet expansion.

But with the portfolio allocation issue still pending, the entire exercise has been put on hold for the time being.

> **Key Points**
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Bajrang Dal men create ruckus at footwear outlet in Dehradun

Write 'Jihadi' on managers' name tags

OUR CORRESPONDENT

DEHRADUN: A purported video has been widely circulating on social media showing a group of Bajrang Dal activists creating a ruckus at a footwear showroom in Dehradun and writing 'Jihadi' on the name tags of two Muslim staffers, alleging harassment of Hindu employees at the outlet.

The incident occurred on Thursday at the footwear outlet located on Rajpur Road, sources said.

Vikas Verma, Uttarakhand state convenor of the Bajrang Dal, who led the group, claimed they acted on a complaint alleging harassment of Hindu staffers by the outlet's manager and co-manager.

> The incident occurred on Thursday at the footwear outlet located on Rajpur Road, sources said

"The two Muslim managers were targeting Hindu employees by making them work overtime for four hours without paying any extra money. They also falsely accused them of theft to cut their salaries," Verma told news agency.

Asked if they reported the matter to the police first, Verma claimed that the authorities did not act on similar issues raised by them in the past.

From Page 1

North India

could see these worsen into a "severe heatwave" between May 19 and May 23. Under IMD classifications, a severe heatwave is declared when maximum temperatures exceed 47 degrees Celsius or rise more than 6.4 degrees Celsius above normal. A standard heatwave is declared when temperatures cross 45 degrees Celsius or climb between 4.5 and 6.4 degrees above normal.

Across most of central India, northern peninsular India, and large parts of Gujarat, Rajasthan and Haryana, maximum temperatures were already sitting between 40 and 45 degrees Celsius as of May 16. The IMD has also predicted a further rise of three to five degrees Celsius in maximum temperatures across many parts of northwest India over the next three to four days.

This is not the first such episode this season. A heatwave had already swept through parts of the country around April 13, with the IMD issuing alerts across several states until approximately April 29. That period also brought reports of heat-related deaths. Two school teachers died in Odisha from sunstroke on April 24 and 25 while carrying out census-related fieldwork. In West Bengal, at least four deaths were reported during the first phase of assembly election voting on April 23.

Not all parts of the country are facing the same conditions. The IMD has also announced that the Southwest Monsoon is likely to arrive over Kerala around May 26, with a margin of plus or minus four days. Conditions are already becoming favourable for the monsoon to advance into parts of the southeast Arabian Sea, the Bay of Bengal and the remaining sections of the Andaman Islands over the next two to three days. Heavy rainfall is expected over the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and parts of northeast India in the coming days. An orange alert for thunderstorms with hail has been issued for Karnataka, while thunderstorms and gusty winds are expected over Chhattisgarh, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha and Andhra Pradesh.

Health authorities have advised people to avoid going out during afternoon hours, drink enough water and limit outdoor activity where possible. The warnings are particularly directed at outdoor workers, the elderly and children, who face the highest health risks as temperatures continue to rise across the region.

India, Sweden

space, emerging technologies, defence and security, small and medium enterprises, research, and people-to-people ties. Bilateral trade between the two countries stood at USD 7.75 billion in 2025. Both leaders also agreed to pursue new opportunities within the framework of the India-EU Strategic Partnership and the recently concluded India-EU Free Trade Agreement.

Kristersson took note of India's strides in digital transformation and Artificial Intelligence, while Modi extended an invitation for greater Swedish participation in India's economic growth. The contribution of the Indian community living in Sweden also received warm acknowledgement from the Swedish side.

Beyond economics, the leaders discussed regional and global concerns, including the need for reform of the United Nations and multilateral organisations, with both sides agreeing to work together in multilateral forums.

Crown Princess Victoria joined the meeting, conveying greetings from King Carl XVI Gustav and Queen Silvia. Modi, in turn, passed along warm wishes to the King on the occasion of his 80th birthday.

The visit carried a cultural dimension as well. Modi received Sweden's highest honour, the Royal Order of the Polar Star, Degree Commander Grand Cross, conferred upon him by Crown Princess Victoria. The award, instituted in 1748, is reserved for recognising personal endeavours for Sweden or Swedish interests, including distinguished public service. It is the highest distinction that can be given to a head of government, and marks Modi's 31st international honour. Jaiswal noted that Modi dedicated the award to the historic ties between the two countries and to the warmth shared by their peoples.

Modi and Kristersson also exchanged gifts honouring Rabindranath Tagore, the first non-European Nobel Laureate, reflecting the intellectual and civilisational links between India and Sweden. The exchange held particular resonance this year, which marks the centenary of Tagore's historic visit to Sweden in 1926.

On the sidelines, Modi met Robert Maersk Uggla, Chairman of Maersk, to explore investment opportunities in maritime logistics and port infrastructure, as well as green shipping and skilled mobility.

The visit opened with Modi meeting members of the Indian diaspora in Gothenburg, where performances included a rendition of the bhajan Vaishnava Jana To by Swedish opera singer Charlotta Huldt and a Bharatanatyam performance by students of Lilla Akademien.

CNG prices

appreciation of USD," it said.

Even after the latest revision, CNG would still offer up to 45 per cent savings towards the running cost when compared to vehicles running on alternate fuel at the current level of prices.

Fire breaks

The movement of 13 passenger trains was disrupted on the corridor. Repair work on the Delhi-bound up line was completed around 1 pm, while work on the down Delhi-Mumbai line wrapped up earlier, at 8.30 am, said Kota Railway PRO Ravindra Lakhara. A relief train and a tower wagon were dispatched to support rescue and restoration efforts, with Divisional Railway Manager Ajay Kumar Kalra monitoring operations throughout.

Separately, a van carrying equipment for overhead electric line repairs overturned between Shyamnagar and Alot in Ratlam after a cow strayed onto the road. Five railway staffers were injured, one of them critically. All were taken to hospital and later referred to Kota for further treatment.

At Kota station, affected passengers were offered Rs 5,000 per person as initial compensation for ticket fare and luggage loss, disbursed in envelopes. However, many refused the amount and demanded that a First Information Report be registered over the destruction of their belongings.

"I have lost my year's earnings as my luggage has been gutted. I have nothing in hand now," said a woman travelling from Goa to Haryana, who also alleged that the railway's rescue response was inadequate. Another passenger from Maharashtra claimed his belongings were reduced to ashes due to what he described as negligence on the part of the railways, alleging that railway staff prioritised parcels and courier items over passengers' luggage.

A high-level inquiry into the cause of the fire has been ordered, officials confirmed.

Gang rape

According to the complaint filed on April 11, the elder sister had faced nearly four years of sexual assault, blackmail and exploitation by a group of men. A key accused, identified as Mahipal, allegedly lured her into a relationship, recorded private videos, and used them to extort money and force sexual acts. The complaint named eight individuals, including Shivraj, Gopal, Vijaram, Dinesh, Manoj and Pukhraj, accusing them of repeated assault and threats.

Unable to bear the prolonged abuse and pressure, the elder sister died by suicide on March 20, police said. Her younger sister later alleged that the same group began targeting her, threatening to release the videos and continuing the pattern of assault and intimidation. She approached the police multiple times and warned in writing that she might take her own life if action was not taken.

Despite an FIR being registered, the family has alleged that no decisive steps were taken for over a month. The younger woman also claimed that the accused continued to threaten her openly and said they would not face consequences.

On Friday, she climbed a water tank to protest and demand arrests. She later consumed poison and died while being taken to hospital, according to police and family accounts.

Authorities said two accused have been detained and several others are being questioned. Additional Superintendent of Police Raghunath Garg supervised evidence collection, while a forensic team has been deployed. Statements of family members are being recorded as part of a renewed investigation.

Bhopal Lakhawat, Additional Superintendent of Police, Jodhpur Rural, said, "We have registered an FIR in which many names of the accused are mentioned. Our investigation officer is interrogating the accused, and we will soon take necessary action." Jodhpur Superintendent of Police PD Nitya also confirmed that Mahipal and another accused have been detained and the process of arrest is underway.

Amid mounting pressure, authorities have transferred the local police outpost in-charge to the lines and initiated a departmental inquiry against the station house officer and the deputy superintendent of police.

Community leaders have warned of wider protests if arrests are not made. Hanumangarh Singh, president of the Marwar Rajput Samaj, said, "We demand immediate arrests and strict action against officers who failed to act in time. If the administration does not act, we will organise a bigger protest across the state."

After an initial stand-off, the family agreed to a post-mortem. The case remains under investigation.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

WHO declares

(620 miles) from the outbreak's epicentre in the eastern province of Ituri, suggesting a possible wider spread. It said the patient had visited Ituri and that other suspected cases have also been reported in North Kivu province, which is one of Congo's most populous provinces and borders Ituri.

Ebola is highly contagious and can be contracted via bodily fluids such as vomit, blood or semen. The disease it causes is rare, but severe and often fatal.

Health authorities say the current outbreak, first confirmed on Friday, is caused by the Bundibugyo virus, a rare variant of the Ebola disease that has no approved therapeutics or vaccines. Although more than 20 Ebola outbreaks have taken place in Congo and Uganda, this is only the third time the Bundibugyo virus has been detected.

Congo accounts for all except two of the cases, both of which were reported in Uganda, the WHO said.

The Bundibugyo virus was first detected in Uganda's Bundibugyo district during a 2007-2008 outbreak that infected 149 people and killed 37 people. The second time was in 2012 in an outbreak in Isiro, Congo, where 57 cases and 29 deaths were reported.

WHO's emergency declaration is meant to spur donor agencies and countries into action. However, the global response to previous declarations has been mixed.

In 2024, when the WHO declared mpox outbreaks in Congo and elsewhere in Africa a global emergency, experts at the time said it did little to get supplies like diagnostic tests, medicines and vaccines to affected countries quickly.

Africa CDC Director-General Dr Jean Kaseya said Saturday that a high number of active cases remain in the community, particularly in Mongwalu, where the first cases were reported, "significantly complicating containment and contact tracing efforts."

Violent conflict with militants, some backed by the Islamic State group, as well as constant population movement due to mining, both within Congo and across the border with Uganda, have also posed a major challenge to response efforts.

Officials first reported the spread of the disease in Ituri province, close to Uganda and South Sudan, on Friday. On Saturday, the Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention reported 336 suspected cases and 87 deaths in Congo.

"There are significant uncertainties regarding the true number of infected persons and geographic spread associated with this event at the present time. In addition, there is limited understanding of the epidemiological links with known or suspected cases," Tedros said.

The two cases in Uganda include one person whom the country said had travelled from Congo and died at a hospital in Uganda's capital, Kampala, and another, the WHO said, had also travelled from Congo.

The WHO said the high percentage of positive cases among samples tested, the spread to Kampala and Uganda and the clusters of deaths across Ituri "all point towards a potentially much larger outbreak than what is currently being detected and reported, with significant local and regional risk of spread."

Kaseya said slow detection delayed the response and gave the outbreak time to spread.

"This outbreak started in April. So far, we don't know the index case. It means we don't know how far the magnitude of this outbreak is," said Kaseya, using a term for the first detectable case of an epidemic.

The earliest known suspected victim, a 59-year-old man, developed symptoms on April 24 and died in hospital in Ituri on April 27.

By the time health authorities were first alerted to the outbreak via social media on May 5, 50 deaths had already been recorded, the Africa CDC said.

The WHO said at least four deaths have been reported among healthcare workers who showed Ebola symptoms.

AS MANY AS 14 MEMBERS OF CABINET ARE NEW FACES

Satheesan announces Kerala Cabinet ahead of swearing-in ceremony

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala Chief Minister-designate V D Satheesan on Sunday unveiled a 20-member Cabinet ahead of the swearing-in of the new government, comprising experienced leaders and 14 first-time ministers, including two women and two members of the Scheduled Caste community.

Addressing a press conference after submitting the list of ministers to Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar at Lok Bhavan, Satheesan said the names were finalised after discussions among alliance leaders, taking into account social and regional balance within the coalition.

As many as 14 members of the Cabinet are new faces.

The ministers announced include senior Congress leaders and former ministers Ramesh Chennithala, K Muraleedharan, and A P Anil Kumar, besides KPCC chief Sunny Joseph.

Senior IUML leader P K Kunhalikutty, RSP leader Shibu Baby John, Kerala Congress leader Mons Joseph, and Kerala Congress (Jacob) leader Anoop Jacob will also be ministers.

All of them have served as ministers in the previous UDF government.

The new faces in the Cabinet are C P John and IUML leaders N Shamsuddin, K M Shaji, P K Basheer, and V E Abdul Gafoor.

Congress leaders P C Vishnunadh, Roji M John, Bindu Krishna, T Siddique, K A Thulasi, and O J Janeesh are also among the new ministers from the party.

The UDF has also decided to appoint senior legislator Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan as Speaker of the Assembly, while Shanimol Usman will serve as Deputy Speaker.

The chief whip will be from Kerala Congress (J) and will be announced by party chairman P J Joseph.

Satheesan said several deserving leaders could not be accommodated in the Cabinet despite the Congress securing 63 seats, calling it one of the party's biggest victories in the state.

"Let new faces come. There should be opportunity for all," he said.

When asked about the exclusion of some prominent names, he said there could be others who were equally or more deserving.

"However, when a party like Congress makes decisions, factors such as social and regional balance have to be considered. We have 63 MLAs after a historic victory, but could accommodate only 11 in the Cabinet," he said.

Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar receives the list of Cabinet ministers from the Chief Minister-designate V D Satheesan, at the Lok Bhavan, in Thiruvananthapuram PTI

Highlights

- Ministers announced include senior Congress leaders Ramesh Chennithala, K Muraleedharan, and A P Anil Kumar, besides KPCC chief Sunny Joseph
- The new faces in the Cabinet are C P John and IUML leaders N Shamsuddin, K M Shaji, P K Basheer, and V E Abdul Gafoor

SEEKS PM'S APOLOGY

Rahul slams Pradhan over NEET 'leak', CBSE evaluation row

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday slammed Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan for "failing" students across age groups amid the NEET-UG paper leak row and CBSE evaluation concerns, and sought an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi for "destroying" the future of lakhs of children.

The leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha also attacked Pradhan over the rollout of the CBSE's three-language policy in schools.

Questioning the "silence" of Prime Minister Modi on these issues, Gandhi asked him why he was not sacking Pradhan despite repeated paper leaks during his tenure.

"First the NEET paper leak affected 22 lakh students. Then CBSE Class 12 students received unexpectedly low marks from a broken OSM system - many losing their college eligibility.

"Now lakhs of CBSE Class 9 students suddenly asked to learn a new language from July 1, with no teachers, no textbooks, and Class 6 books being handed to 14-year-olds as a 'transitional' fix," he said in a post on X.

Gandhi alleged that Pradhan has "failed" every single age group of students.

"Three exams. Three age groups. One Minister. Dharmendra Pradhan ji has not failed once. He has failed every single age group of India's students at once.

"Every announcement plunges children deeper into uncertainty. Every failure goes unpunished. The Education Ministry has become a department of disasters," Gandhi said.

"Prime Minister Modi ji - can you at least apologise to the lakhs of children whose futures you and your Minister have destroyed?" the former Congress chief asked, using the hashtag '#SackPradhan'.

In another post earlier, Gandhi said, "NEET 2024: Paper leaked. Exam not cancelled. Minister did not resign. CBI set up an investigation. A committee was formed."

The National Testing Agency cancelled the National Eligibility cum Entrance Exam (Undergraduate) held on May 3 amid allegations of irregularities. The re-exam has been scheduled for June 21.

"Mr Modi, the country is asking you some questions - answer them! Why are paper leaks happening repeatedly? Why are you silent time and again on this 'Pariksha pe Charcha'? Why aren't you dismissing the education minister who keeps failing repeatedly?" The Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha asked, using the hashtag "#SackPradhan".

Closer Look

- Gandhi asked why PM was not sacking Pradhan despite repeated paper leaks during his tenure
- Gandhi alleged that Pradhan has 'failed' every single age group of students

Great Nicobar project a recipe for ecological disaster: Cong to Rajnath

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Sunday wrote to Defence minister Rajnath Singh on the Great Nicobar Island Project, saying the project in its present shape and form is a recipe for "ecological disaster".

Congress leaders have been flagging concerns over the project, claiming it would have a bearing on the ecology and tribal rights in the region.

In his letter to the minister, he said while there can be no two opinions on the need to strengthen India's defences, he suggested some measures to help strengthen its strategic capabilities within the Great Nicobar project.

He said such measures have been proposed by naval officers in their writings and can help improve the nation's defence without much damage to the area's ecology.

Ramesh shared the letter on X, saying, "After writing to the Union Minister of Environment, Forests, & Climate Change and the Union Minister of Tribal Affairs, I have written to the Raksha Mantri on the Great Nicobar Island Project."

Ramesh, who has earlier served as Environment minister, said on May 1, the Government of India had issued a press note titled 'The Great Nicobar Island Project: FAQs'.

On May 10, 2026, he said he had written to the Union Minister of Environment, Forests and Climate Change on how these FAQs present a "completely false picture" on the project's environmental clearances which, in reality, have been given on very dubious grounds.

"On May 13, 2026, I wrote to the Union Minister of Tribal Affairs on how the FAQs misrepresent totally the position regarding the fulfilment of the provisions of the Forest Rights Act, 2006 as part of the project's clearance process which flagrantly violate, in letter and spirit, the individual and collective rights given to tribal communities by Parliament.

'CONGRESS WIPED OUT IN GUJARAT LOCAL POLLS'

BJP-led NDA governs 80% of India: Amit Shah

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GANDHINAGAR: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday hailed the BJP's recent victory in West Bengal polls and said the party and its NDA allies now govern 80 per cent of the country's territory.

Addressing a gathering after inaugurating and laying the foundation stone for projects worth Rs 620 crore for the Gandhinagar Municipal Corporation, he said the Congress was "wiped out" in Gujarat's local body elections. The AAP "could not even open an account", he said.

Shah said the BJP's "unstoppable journey of development" in Gujarat began under Prime Minister Narendra Modi and was later carried forward by former chief ministers Anandiben Patel and Vijay Rupani and current CM Bhupendra Patel.

"As a result of this pro-development approach of the BJP, Congress was completely wiped out in the recent local body elections. Even if we search far and wide with binoculars, Congress is nowhere to be seen," Shah said.

"And people from AAP, claiming 'we will win this, we will win that', got wiped out in Delhi, and here they couldn't even open an account here," he added.

Shah praised BJP workers for maintaining close contact with people and resolving their issues, saying this had strengthened public trust in the party.

Recalling the COVID-19 pandemic period, Shah said BJP workers across Gujarat served people selflessly.

"Somewhere they delivered food kits to the poor, somewhere they took those who had no one to hospitals, somewhere they arranged testing, and somewhere BJP workers managed vaccination lines without taking their own vaccine," he said.

Union Home minister Amit Shah being greeted by Union minister Piyush Goyal at Gandhinagar campus of National Institute of Design, Gujarat PTI

TN Speaker lauds CM Vijay as 'different kind of political leader'

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Assembly speaker J C D Prabhakar on Sunday said that Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay is expediting all projects and closely monitoring every detail related to them.

"It is customary for legislators and ministers to conduct reviews whenever a new government is formed. Our CM is expediting all projects and keeps track of every detail at his fingertips—which constituency has which project, who is carrying out the work, and where it is being implemented," he told reporters while inspecting the Thousand Lights constituency in Chennai.

Claiming that the state government was functioning efficiently, the Speaker said the CM had been proactive in fulfilling the promises made by the government and that his performance had been excellent.

"The orders he (Vijay) issued on his first day in office, along with the subsequent directives, have earned the people's respect and approval," he said, adding that "he has emerged as a different kind of political leader."

Responding to a question on petitions submitted by two AIADMK factions—one led by party general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami and another headed by S P Velumani—the Speaker said that, under legislative rules, petitions submitted for review are processed in accordance with due legal procedure. MPOST

Curbs on gold, high import duty ruining small jewellers: Akhilesh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday alleged that the economic policies of the government have turned the nation's economy into an "anarth-vyavastha" (disastrous economy), pushing small-scale jewellers to the brink of financial ruin.

Yadav claimed that the jeweller community, already reeling under law-and-order issues, is now being systematically targeted to benefit large corporate houses at the cost of traditional small traders.

He said that the public has grown weary of the current regime's financial mismanagement.

"The policies of the BJP government have turned the country's economy into an "anarth-vyavastha", filling the lives of ordinary people with crisis. Today's jeweller says, we don't want the BJP," he said.

In a statement issued from the party headquarters here, the former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister said the goldsmith community is facing an unprecedented crisis due to a string of detrimental government decisions.

"The issue of the security of jewellers, who are being robbed in broad daylight across Uttar Pradesh, was not even resolved yet, and then came the trade-shattering call for 'Sonabandi' (curbs on gold), followed by the decree to increase import duty on gold by two and a half times," Yadav said.

The SP chief said traditional, small-scale jewellers were already struggling to compete with corporate giants entering the jewellery market.

The new policies, he alleged, feel like a deliberate attempt to wipe them out entirely.

Linking the policy changes to alleged crony capitalism, Yadav charged that the BJP is creating a monopoly for large companies in exchange for political funding.

Mehbooba Mufti backs Hosabale on people-to-people contact with Pak

SRINAGAR: Peoples Democratic Party President Mehbooba Mufti on Sunday endorsed RSS functionary Dattatreya Hosabale's recent remark that people-to-people contact is key to breaking the deadlock with Pakistan and there should always be a window for dialogue.

"The solution to Kashmir lies in dialogue and within the framework of the Constitution. Whatever we have to achieve needs to be done from Delhi and here (Jammu and Kashmir). We believe in engagement and talks. We seek peace with dignity," Mehbooba said at a party workers' convention here.

The former J&K chief minister welcomed Hosabale's statement on the need for dialogue and people-to-people contact with Pakistan, which was endorsed by former Army chief M M Naravane.

In an interview with a news agency recently, the RSS general secretary said Pakistan's military and political leadership have lost India's confidence, and it is time for civil society to lead the way, "because we have a cultural relation and we have been one nation".

"What Hosabale has said now is what (PDP founder) Mufti Mohammad Sayeed advocated till his last breath. Open our roads leading to the other side of Kashmir... Pakistan, China and Central Asia. If (Narendra) Modi ji wants to carve a name for himself, he should resolve the Kashmir issue and involve Pakistan in the process," Mehbooba said.

"I am not saying that Narendra Modi has done nothing for the resolution of the Kashmir issue. He visited Lahore in 2016, but it was followed by the Pathankot attack. Pakistan will have to respond positively to any efforts of outreach from India," Mehbooba added. MPOST

PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti addresses the gathering, Srinagar, Sunday PTI

BJP sets 13-point Kerala agenda

Focuses on OBC outreach, recalibrates minority engagement

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Buoyed by its victory in three seats in the April 9 Kerala Assembly elections, the BJP has unveiled a 13-point political agenda that it said would shape its strategy in the state ahead of the next Lok Sabha elections.

The agenda places a clear focus on consolidating support among Hindu backward communities while recalibrating the party's outreach to minority groups.

The agenda was part of a political resolution adopted at a BJP state core committee meeting held on Saturday and chaired by state president Rajeev Chandrasekhar, a party source said.

According to the source, the party's document does not explicitly outline fresh outreach initiatives towards minority communities, particularly Christians, despite earlier attempts to build closer ties with the community ahead of the Assembly elections.

Those efforts, however, were not sustained for various reasons, the source added.

Regarding minority outreach, the source stated that the party has not discontinued its engagement with the Christian community, noting that its members continue to hold organisational positions in several districts.

However, it has moved away from attempts to build institutional bridges with Church leadership amid the growing political alignment of bishops with the Congress-led UDF.

The informal shift, according to party insiders, followed the Catholic Church's strong Opposition to the Centre's move to introduce the contentious Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) Amendment Bill, 2026, in Parliament—a development that put the BJP on the defensive during the Kerala Assembly election campaign. AGENCIES

Agenda was part of a political resolution adopted at a BJP state core committee meeting

Himachal: 69.16% polling in urban local bodies election

SHIMLA: A turnout of 69.16 per cent was recorded in the election to 51 urban local bodies in Himachal Pradesh on Sunday, officials said.

The polling was peaceful throughout the state, State Chief Election Commissioner Anil Khachi said. He said 72.42 per cent polling was recorded in municipal councils and Nagar Panchayats, and 63.44 per cent in municipal corporations, adding that the percentage could increase slightly.

Voting for 51 urban local bodies commenced at 7 am and concluded at 3 pm. It was held simultaneously in 64 wards in the four municipal corporations of Dharamshala, Solan, Mandi and Palampur, 229 wards in 25 municipal councils and 156 wards in 22 Nagar Panchayats in a single phase, with as many as 1,147 candidates in the fray for the 449 posts.

A 70-year-old man, Anjan Sharma, died near a polling booth while he was on his way to cast his vote in municipal council elections in Chamba. Preliminary reports suggest that he suffered a heart attack.

The voting percentage was 63.72 in the municipal corporations of Dharamshala and Palampur in Kangra district, 68.78 per cent in Mandi and 58.32 per cent in Solan. Women voters surpassed men in Kangra and Mandi while male voters exceeded in Solan district Municipal Corporation polls.

The highest polling percentage in municipal councils and Nagar Panchayats was 78.89 in Hamirpur, followed by 77.36 in Shimla, 77 in Una, 76.94 in Solan, 74.51 in Kangra, 73.35 in Mandi, 72.06 in Bilaspur, 68.22 in Chamba, 67.80 in Kullu and 67.24 in Sirmaur district.

The counting of votes for municipal councils and Nagar Panchayats has started. MPOST

Former MP Maheshwar Singh shows his ink-marked finger after casting a vote in ULBs polls, in Kullu, Sunday PTI

'NOT NEW FOR CBSE'

On-Screen Marking system: Edu Ministry dismisses concerns

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi: The Ministry of Education on Sunday dismissed concerns about On-Screen Marking (OSM) affecting students' scores in the class 12 exams, saying it is not new for the CBSE and special attention was given to ensure that the marking remained accurate.

OSM is a norm followed internationally to conduct transparent evaluation, School Education Secretary, Ministry of Education, Sanjay Kumar, said at a press conference here.

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has also reduced the charges for re-evaluation and verification of an answer sheet to Rs 100, Kumar said.

This comes amid concerns being raised by students and parents that the drop in the pass percentage in the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) class 12 exams is due to OSM.

Kumar also said that out of 98 lakh answer sheets evaluated this year, more than 13,000 were manually checked as there were some legibility issues despite repeated scanning of these sheets.

The school education secretary said the OSM system is not something new nor has it been implemented for the first time.

"The CBSE had introduced OSM in 2014. At that time, from a technical perspective, it was felt that continuing it immediately would not be feasible because of the existing infrastructure and setup. However, we have reintroduced it this year," he said.

He said a major advantage of introducing OSM is the flexibility it provides.

"Earlier, when the CBSE conducted evaluation or marking, it was generally done within the geographical jurisdiction of the respective regional offices. However, with OSM, it has now become possible to have answer sheets evaluated even outside the regional office area," the school education secretary explained.

Kumar said OSM is being used by many institutions internationally as well as at the national level.

"If we look at school boards, it is used by the International Baccalaureate (IB) and Cambridge boards as well. In fact, it has become a norm internationally because through technology, it enables us to conduct the entire system in a more transparent manner," he said.

On the evaluation process, Kumar said, "For class 12, 98 lakh sheets were scanned and three levels of security were followed during the process."

During the evaluation process, it was found that in some answer sheets, despite repeated scanning, there were some legibility issues because the ink used was of a very light colour, he said.

Key Points

- 'OSM is a norm followed internationally to conduct transparent evaluation'
- CBSE has also reduced charges for re-evaluation and verification of an answer sheet to Rs 100, Kumar said

Nation Briefs

RAJASTHAN BJP LEADER FOUND HANGING FROM A TREE; PROBE UNDERWAY

JAIPUR: A BJP leader was found hanging from a tree in Rajasthan's Banswara district, police said on Sunday. The deceased was identified as Arjun Singh Maida (47), a district secretary of the BJP and a resident of Junakheda village. According to ASI Ramesh Chand of Danpur police station, an argument reportedly took place between Maida and his wife on Saturday night, after which he left home. He was later found hanging from a tree in the district. A case was registered based on a complaint filed by his son Abhimanyu, he said. Police said injury marks were found on the body and the exact cause of death would be ascertained after the post-mortem report is received. Investigators are probing all possible angles in the case, they said.

RANGASAMY RESIGNS FROM THATTANCHAVADY, RETAINS MANGALAM

PUDUCHERRY: Chief Minister N Rangasamy resigned from the Thattanchavady Assembly constituency on Sunday and retained the Mangalam seat. Rangasamy contested from these two seats in the April 9 Assembly polls and won in both constituencies. Secretary to the Assembly J Dayalane told news agency that the Chief Minister resigned from the Thattanchavady seat. Necessary notification declaring vacancy of the constituency would be issued in the next few days, he said. Rangasamy assumed office on May 13, along with ministers A Namassivayam and Malladi Krishna Rao.

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FROM 34 TO 38

Ordinance issued to increase Apex Court judges' strength by 4

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The Law ministry notified the ordinance on Saturday, which amended the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Act, 1956, to increase the sanctioned strength of the top court
- » So far, the sanctioned strength of the top court was 34, including the CJI
- » Now, the number of judges has been increased by four, taking the sanctioned strength to 38
- » The top court will now have 37 judges, other than the CJI
- » With the apex court having two vacancies at present, and the ordinance coming into force immediately, the SC Collegium will now have to recommend six names for appointment as judges in the top court

» The strength of the Supreme Court was last increased from 30 to 33 (excluding the CJI) in 2019

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government has promulgated an ordinance to increase the strength of the Supreme Court from the present 34 judges to 38, including the Chief Justice of India.

The Law ministry notified the ordinance on Saturday, which amended the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Act, 1956, to increase the sanctioned strength of the top court.

So far, the sanctioned strength of the top court was 34, including the Chief Justice of India (CJI). Now, the number of judges has been increased by four, taking the sanctioned strength to 38.

The top court will now have 37 judges, other than the CJI.

With the apex court having two vacancies at present, and the ordinance coming into force immediately, the Supreme Court Collegium will now have to recommend six names for appointment as judges in the top court.

A bill will be brought in the Monsoon Session of Parliament to convert the ordinance – an executive order – into a law passed by Parliament.

The Union Cabinet had cleared a draft bill on May 5 to increase the number of apex court judges.

The strength of the Supreme Court was last increased from 30 to 33 (excluding the CJI) in 2019.

The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Act, as originally enacted in 1956, put the maximum number of judges (excluding the CJI) at 10.

This number was increased to 13 by the Supreme Court (Number of Judges), Amendment Act, 1960, and to 17 by another amendment to the law. The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Act, 1986, augmented the strength of judges from 17 to 25, excluding the CJI.

A fresh amendment in 2009 further increased the strength from 25 to 30.

Article 124(3) of the Constitution lists the qualifications required to become a Supreme Court judge.

An Indian citizen who has either served as a high court judge for at least five years, or as an advocate for 10 years, or is a distinguished jurist, can be appointed to the top court.

The strength of the Supreme Court is increased based on the recommendations of the CJI, who writes to the Union law minister.

After consulting the finance ministry, the Department of Justice under the law ministry moves the Cabinet with a draft bill.

Shah begins 3-day Chhattisgarh visit; to chair Central Zonal Council meeting

Visit will give new momentum to development works in state, says CM

MPOST BUREAU

RAIPUR: Union Home Minister Amit Shah arrived in Raipur on Sunday on a three-day visit to Chhattisgarh during which he will attend a series of programmes and chair a meeting of the Central Zonal Council in Bastar region.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai said Shah's visit will give new momentum to development works in the state and further strengthen the government's resolve for a safe and prosperous Bastar.

Shah landed at Swami Vivekananda Airport here shortly after 8 pm and was received by CM Vishnu Deo Sai, Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma, state ministers, BJP MPs, MLAs and other leaders of the party.

Sai and Sharma reached the airport in a single carcade while other leaders arrived in a bus in keeping with the austerity call given by Prime Minister Narendra Modi amid the West Asia crisis. In a post on 'X', Sai said: "A warm welcome and greetings to Union Minister of Home Affairs and Cooperation, Amit Shah Ji, in Chhattisgarh, the 'nanihal' (the place of Lord Ram's maternal grandparents) home of lord shri Ram and the sacred land of Mother Kaushalya". With the steadfast support of the Central government, Chhattisgarh has been continuously advancing towards a bright future of peace, good governance, and development, Sai said.

"Thanks to the Home Minister's unwavering resolve and guidance, along with the dedicated efforts of the 'Double Engine' government, Bastar today stands liberated from Naxalism and is soaring to new heights of progress," he said.

Union Home minister Amit Shah is greeted by Chhattisgarh CM Vishnudev Sai during his arrival at Swami Vivekanada Airport, in Raipur

On Monday, at around 10.40 am, Shah will flag off new vehicles for the state police emergency response service 'Dial 112' and mobile forensic science laboratory from the parade ground of Police Training School in Raipur. He will then leave for Bastar and visit Netanar village, where he will inaugurate a 'Jan Suvidha Kendra'. Shah will then go to Amar Vatika in Jagdalpur to pay tribute to security personnel who laid down their lives in the service of the nation.

He will also attend an interaction programme at Bastar Academy of Dance, Art and Literature and meet family members of martyrs security forces personnel.

On Tuesday, he will chair the meeting of the Central Zonal Council in Jagdalpur from 11 am to 2 pm.

Myanmar-based drug kingpin held

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has arrested Myanmar-based drug kingpin Thanchintuang alias Chintuang alias Tluanga from Delhi in a major crackdown on transnational drug trafficking networks operating along the India-Myanmar border.

The Chin State resident was a key figure in trafficking methamphetamine and heroin through routes linking Myanmar with Mizoram, Manipur, Assam and Tripura, with operations also extending into Bangladesh, officials said, adding that the arrest followed months of surveillance and coordinated operations involving multiple agencies. Chintuang is wanted in several narcotics cases, including a 2024 seizure near Dulte involving 14 kg of methamphetamine and 2.8 kg of heroin. The NCB estimated the syndicate's operations to be worth nearly Rs 120 crore.

CENSUS 2027

Houselisting operations begin in multiple states

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Field operations under Phase I of Census 2027, covering the Houselisting and Housing Census (HLO), have begun in Rajasthan, Meghalaya, Maharashtra, Jharkhand and areas under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) as part of the nationwide census exercise.

Officials said enumerators have already started door-to-door HLO surveys in several states and Union Territories, including Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Bihar, Chandigarh, Chhattisgarh, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, Telangana and Uttarakhand.

The Self-Enumeration process has also commenced in Gujarat, Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh and Puducherry and will continue till May 31, 2026. Field operations in these regions are scheduled from June 1 to June 30. In Uttar Pradesh, self-enumeration will continue till May 21, while house-to-house surveys are set to begin from May 22.

According to officials, over 1.44 crore households across 25 states and Union Territories have already completed self-enumeration through the official census portal, marking a significant step towards the digitisation of census operations.

Yogi govt tightens noose on cow slaughter and smuggling in UP

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government under Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has enforced one of the country's strictest legal frameworks for cow protection and cattle welfare, with the Uttar Pradesh Prevention of Cow Slaughter (Amendment) Ordinance, 2020, emerging as a key pillar of its policy. Implemented on June 11, 2020, the law is being projected by the government as a reflection of its commitment to curbing cow slaughter and cattle smuggling across the state.

Before 2017, concerns were frequently raised over illegal slaughter, cattle smuggling networks, and the condition of stray cattle in several districts of Uttar Pradesh. After assuming office, the Yogi government treated cow protection as a governance issue and introduced stricter legal and administrative measures.

The original Prevention of Cow Slaughter Act was enacted in 1955, but the amended law introduced in 2020 significantly enhanced penalties. Under the revised provisions, any person found guilty of cow slaughter or attempting it can face rigorous imprisonment ranging from three to 10 years along with a fine between Rs 3 lakh and Rs 5 lakh. Repeat offenders can face double punishment.

The law also criminalises cruelty towards cattle. Failing to provide food or water to cows, injuring them, or abandoning them in life-threatening conditions can attract imprisonment from one to seven years and fines between Rs 1 lakh and Rs 3 lakh.

The Act further provides for confiscation of vehicles used in illegal transportation of cattle and makes offences non-bailable. Authorities can also publicly display photographs of absconding accused persons.

According to government figures, nearly 36,000 accused involved in cow slaughter and cattle smuggling cases were arrested between 2017 and 2025. Action under the Goonda Act was taken against 13,793 accused, while 14,305 cases were registered under the Gangster Act.

Additionally, 178 accused were booked under the National Security Act, and properties worth over Rs 83.32 crore were confiscated. MPOST

Captagon mfg unit busted in Dehradun

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has busted an illegal Captagon manufacturing unit in Dehradun, Uttarakhand, under Operation RAZEPILL, seizing 227.2 kg of Captagon tablets and powder and arresting a Syrian national in connection with the case.

Officials said the operation was carried out following intelligence inputs received from international agencies. Forensic examination later confirmed the seized substance to be Captagon, a synthetic stimulant widely abused in parts of the Middle East.

According to investigators, the Syrian national arrested earlier in Delhi's Neb Sarai area disclosed during questioning that the drugs had been manufactured at a facility operating under the name "M/s Green Herbal" in Dehradun since November 2025. Another Syrian associate was also allegedly involved in running the operation.

Acting on the information, NCB teams conducted a late-night raid at the factory on Saturday. During the search, officials recovered sophisticated pharmaceutical machinery used for large-scale drug production, including tablet-making, granule-processing, capsule-filling, coating and blister-packaging machines. Investigators also seized raw materials, chemical compounds, empty capsules and packaging containers believed to be intended for drug distribution. Officials said evidence collection and forensic documentation continued under judicial supervision. Preliminary investigations revealed that the factory premises were allegedly being rented out for around Rs 50,000 per day for illegal manufacturing activities. Authorities are also probing financial transactions linked to the operation.

The NCB further found links between the factory owner and earlier narcotics cases investigated by Patiala House and the NCB's Delhi Zonal Unit.

The factory owner has also been arrested.

HP civic polls: BJP sweeps Manali, Cong scores in Dalhousie & Nahan

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: The BJP-backed candidates registered a significant victory in Himachal Pradesh's urban local body polls, sweeping all seven wards of the Manali Municipal Council in Kullu district, while the ruling Congress managed to edge out the BJP in Dalhousie and Nahan.

Polling for 51 urban local bodies, including four municipal corporations at Dharamshala, Solan, Palampur and Mandi, was held on Sunday. While the results for the four municipal corporations will be declared on May 31 along with the Panchayat election results, the State Election Commission (SEC) announced the outcomes for 25 municipal councils and 22 nagar panchayats. The elections are being seen as a key political test for both the ruling Congress and the opposition BJP ahead of the 2027 Himachal Pradesh Assembly polls.

According to the SEC, around 72 per cent voting was recorded in 47 municipal councils and nagar panchayats, while the four municipal corporations registered 63.61 per cent turnout.

Polling was conducted for 449 posts across 64 wards in municipal corporations, 229 wards in municipal councils and 156 wards in nagar panchayats. A total of 1,147 candidates were in the fray. Congress-backed candidates won six out of nine wards in the Nurpur Municipal Council, while BJP-backed candidates secured the remaining three.

In Rampur Municipal Council, BJP-backed candidates won five of the nine wards, leaving four to Congress-supported nominees.

Congress-backed candidates swept all three wards of the Nahan Municipal Council, located in the home constituency of BJP state president Rajeev Bindal. In Theog Municipal Council, both Congress- and BJP-backed candidates won three wards each.

The BJP also scored a major victory in Tahliwal Nagar Panchayat in Una district, considered the stronghold of Deputy CM Mukesh Agnihotri, winning five out of seven wards.

Nerwa in Shimla district recorded the highest turnout at 89.08 per cent.

Lucknow demolition drive: Lawyers clash with cops

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

INSIGHT

- » Police resorted to lathi-charge amid protests and sloganeering by advocates opposing the action being carried out on the orders of the HC
- » During the drive, angry lawyers raised slogans and entered into heated arguments with officials

LUCKNOW: Demolition drives against illegal lawyers' chambers in Lucknow turned tense on Sunday as police resorted to lathi-charge amid protests and sloganeering by advocates opposing the action being carried out on the orders of the Allahabad High Court.

Teams from the municipal corporation, police and district administration began demolishing the structures from early morning in areas around the Health Bhawan and district court complex. Heavy police deployment, including PAC personnel, was made in anticipation of resistance from lawyers.

During the drive, angry lawyers raised slogans and entered into heated arguments with officials. The situation escalated after some protesters allegedly tried to obstruct the demolition work, following which police used force to disperse the crowd.

In a dramatic protest, one lawyer locked himself inside his chamber and claimed that no notice had been served to him. He alleged that only selected chambers were being targeted and reportedly attempted to hang himself inside the structure before being stopped.

A woman advocate accused officials of acting selectively and alleged collusion in the demolition process. She said lawyers should have been provided an alternative arrangement before the chambers were removed. She further alleged that several chambers not marked for demolition were also razed, while some influential occupants escaped action.

The HC had ordered the demolition of around 240 illegal chambers constructed near Health Bhawan and the kachahri area. Notices had earlier been pasted by the Lucknow Municipal Corporation, giving occupants time to remove the structures voluntarily.

After the deadline expired and the encroachments remained, demolition action was initiated.

Officials said illegal chambers had come up along key stretches including the road from Health Bhawan crossing to Chakbast crossing, near Sadar tehsil and the registration office, and on roads connecting Residency, CMO office, Health Bhawan and the district and sessions court.

Authorities said many of the structures had encroached upon roads, footpaths and drains.

Several photocopy shops operating from the encroached areas were also removed during the drive.

Officials pointed out that a similar action had been carried out in October last year when around 20 illegal chambers were demolished, but many of them were later rebuilt.

India's urban poor face 'dangerous' indoor heat even at night, says study

'Nighttime temperatures inside homes rarely dropped below 31 degrees Celsius'

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

REPRESENTATIVE PIC

KEY POINTS

- » Researchers found that indoor temperatures frequently crossed 32 degrees Celsius and remained above heat stress thresholds for prolonged periods
- » Humidity levels inside homes also stayed consistently above 75 percent during nighttime hours

LUCKNOW: Residents of low and middle-income households in Indian cities are facing chronic indoor heat exposure, with temperatures inside homes remaining dangerously high even during nighttime and outside the peak summer season, according to a new study conducted in Chennai.

The study, released by Climate Trends during the India Heat Summit 2026, monitored temperature and humidity levels inside 50 homes in Chennai between October 2025 and April 2026.

Researchers found that indoor temperatures frequently crossed 32 degrees Celsius and remained above heat stress thresholds for prolonged periods, exposing residents to months of continuous thermal discomfort.

The findings point to a growing but largely invisible urban crisis in India, where millions living in densely populated concrete homes continue to suffer from trapped indoor heat long after sunset.

Researchers found that nighttime temperatures inside homes rarely dropped below 31 degrees Celsius, even during relatively cooler months. Indoor spaces recorded their highest temperatures between 8 pm and 9 pm as concrete roofs and walls released heat absorbed during the day. In several homes, temperatures remained above 34 degrees Celsius deep into the night.

The study highlighted that the problem is not limited to heatwaves alone but reflects continuous baseline heat exposure faced by urban residents in Indian cities.

Humidity levels inside homes also stayed consistently above 75 percent during nighttime hours, worsening discomfort and reducing the body's ability to cool itself naturally. Residents reported sleep disruption, exhaustion and persistent fatigue linked to the prolonged indoor heat.

Addressing the India Heat Summit virtually, Union Minister for New and Renewable Energy Pralhad Joshi said rising temperatures and extreme weather events are affecting cities, villages and everyday life across the country, with heat stress emerging as one of the defining challenges of the time.

The report said reinforced cement concrete structures commonly used in Indian urban housing were a major contributor to indoor heat retention. While high-income households relied on air conditioners, poorer families depended largely on ceiling fans, creating a stark "cooling gap" between income groups.

Aarti Khosla, founder and director of Climate Trends, said the study underlined the urgent need to recognise nighttime indoor heat as a major public health issue in India. She said residents were unable to recover from daytime heat exposure because indoor temperatures remained elevated through the night.

Chair in Maharana Pratap's name to be established at Kurukshetra Univ

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday announced that a study centre and a chair in the name of Maharana Pratap will be established at Kurukshetra University.

Besides, the name of the Government Women's College at Baragarh in Shahzadpur area of Ambala district will be changed to Maharani Padmavati Government College, he said.

The chief minister made these announcements at a state-level function organized at Shahzadpur to mark the Maharana Pratap Jayanti.

He also announced Rs 5 crore for various development works in the Naraingarh assembly constituency, Rs 31 lakh for the construction of a Rajput Hostel and building a pucca drain in Shahzadpur.

Earlier, Saini also unveiled a renovated statue of Maharana Pratap. Governor of Mizoram, General V K Singh (retd), also attended the function.

Saini said that Maharana Pratap was such a great warrior that merely taking his name fills every heart with a wave of patriotism. He said Maharana Pratap was born in the Rajput community at a time when Indian society was overshadowed by injustice and oppression and efforts were being made to destroy our glorious culture and hurt religious sentiments.

Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini addresses the gathering during a state-level function organised to mark Maharana Pratap Jayanti at Shahzadpur, Ambala on Sunday

The great warrior inherited bravery and valour from Maharana Kumbha and Rana Sanga and after assuming power in Mewar, set unparalleled examples of courage and heroism. His horse 'Chetak' and elephant 'Ramprasad' were also extraordinary like him and set examples of sacrifice, Saini said.

The chief minister further said that when Maharana Pratap assumed power in Mewar, half of Mewar had already come under Mughal rule. "To liberate his birthplace and 'karmabhoomi' from the Mughals, Maharana Pratap spent nearly 20 years in forests. He had to eat grass 'rotis' but never accepted defeat," Saini said. He said the Rajput community has given great rulers to the country. The community holds a leading place among those who sacrificed for the honour, pride and dignity of the nation during India's freedom struggle and after Independence, Saini said. The chief minister said that the "life of Maharana Pratap gives us the message that as long as self-respect remains alive, our soul remains alive". MPOST

EDITORIAL

LANGUAGE FAULTLINE

The return of the three-language debate was perhaps inevitable. Language in India has never been merely a medium of instruction; it has always been tied to identity, politics, aspiration and power. With the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) notifying the implementation of the three-language formula for Class 9 from July 1, 2026, two months after the academic session had already begun, the issue has once again moved from policy documents into the centre of national political discourse.

At one level, the idea behind the three-language formula appears both reasonable and even desirable. India is one of the most linguistically diverse countries in the world. Multilingualism is not an exception here but a lived reality. The National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 argues that students should ideally learn three languages, at least two of them native to India, in order to strengthen cultural rootedness, cognitive flexibility and national integration. In theory, few would disagree with the broader objective of encouraging Indian children to engage with more than one language tradition.

Yet India's language debates are never resolved at the level of theory alone. They are shaped by history, memory and political distrust. That is why the three-language formula continues to generate resistance nearly six decades after it was first formally adopted under the National Policy on Education in 1968. The controversy surrounding it today is not simply about classroom instruction. It reflects older anxieties about centralisation, cultural dominance and the fear of linguistic homogenisation.

The strongest opposition has historically emerged from Tamil Nadu, and understanding why requires revisiting the state's political history. Anti-Hindi mobilisation in the region predates Independence. The introduction of compulsory Hindi in schools in 1937 by the then Madras Presidency government triggered intense protests led by Periyar and the Justice Party. For many in Tamil Nadu, Hindi was viewed not as a neutral language but as a vehicle of northern political and cultural dominance. Those anxieties deepened after Independence, particularly during debates around making Hindi the sole official language of the Union.

When the three-language formula was formally introduced in 1968, Tamil Nadu refused to adopt it, arguing that the policy would disproportionately burden non-Hindi-speaking states while effectively giving Hindi-speaking states an advantage. Under C.N. Annadurai, the state adopted its now famous two-language formula — Tamil and English. More than half a century later, Tamil Nadu remains the only state that has consistently resisted the three-language framework.

This history matters because every new language policy is interpreted through the lens of past battles. The Centre repeatedly insists that no language will be imposed and that states retain flexibility in choosing languages. NEP 2020 itself explicitly says that the formula will respect "the aspirations of the people, regions and the Union" and that no language will be imposed on any state. Yet political trust on this issue remains fragile. The fear in southern states is not merely about Hindi instruction itself, but about the gradual expansion of cultural centralisation through educational policy.

At the same time, the debate cannot be reduced entirely to a Hindi versus non-Hindi binary. There is also an important educational and economic dimension that deserves serious attention. English today occupies a unique position in India. It is simultaneously a colonial inheritance, a global language and a tool of social mobility. For millions of Indians, particularly from middle-class and lower-income families, proficiency in English represents access to higher education, technology, international employment and upward mobility.

This is why one aspect of the new framework has generated concern. Under the revised classification, English is being treated as a foreign language, and schools may effectively restrict students from choosing both English and another foreign language within the three-language structure. While the policy seeks to strengthen Indian languages, policymakers must ensure that students are not inadvertently placed at a competitive disadvantage in an increasingly globalised economy. India's future workforce will need both rootedness and global competence. One cannot come at the cost of the other.

There are also practical challenges that expose the gap between policy ambition and implementation reality. CBSE itself has acknowledged that dedicated textbooks are not yet ready and that students may temporarily have to rely on Class 6 materials. Schools facing teacher shortages have been advised to use existing teachers with "functional proficiency" in the language concerned. These are not minor logistical issues. Language education requires trained teachers, pedagogical continuity and carefully designed curriculum structures. Without adequate preparation, the risk is that multilingualism becomes an administrative burden rather than a meaningful educational experience.

India's education system already struggles with uneven learning outcomes, teacher shortages and infrastructure gaps. Adding another layer of curricular complexity without proper groundwork may deepen confusion rather than strengthen learning. The success of any language policy depends less on official declarations and more on whether schools possess the institutional capacity to implement it effectively.

The larger question, however, is whether India can find a language framework that balances diversity with cohesion. A multilingual society inevitably requires some shared communicative bridges. At the same time, India's strength has always rested on accommodating linguistic pluralism rather than flattening it. Attempts to aggressively standardise identity through language have historically generated resistance rather than unity.

The NEP's emphasis on flexibility is therefore important, but flexibility must not remain rhetorical. States must genuinely retain the freedom to adapt language policy to their historical, cultural and social contexts. Equally, regional political parties should avoid reducing every conversation around multilingualism into a simplistic narrative of imposition. There is value in Indian students learning more Indian languages, just as there is value in preserving regional linguistic pride. These goals do not have to be mutually exclusive.

India's language debate ultimately mirrors the complexity of India itself — multilingual, federal, aspirational and deeply sensitive to questions of identity. The challenge before policymakers is not merely to implement a formula but to build trust. Educational reform imposed without consensus often creates political backlash that outlasts the policy itself.

The three-language formula may have returned to classrooms, but the deeper issue remains unresolved: how can India promote national cohesion without unsettling the linguistic diversity that defines its civilisation? That question will continue to shape Indian politics long after this academic session ends.

NATIONAL IMPERATIVE

Why Congress Fears Great Nicobar

From border neglect and strategic drift to opposing the Great Nicobar Project, the Congress continues to stand against initiatives that could redefine India's geopolitical and maritime future

ANIRBAN GANGULY

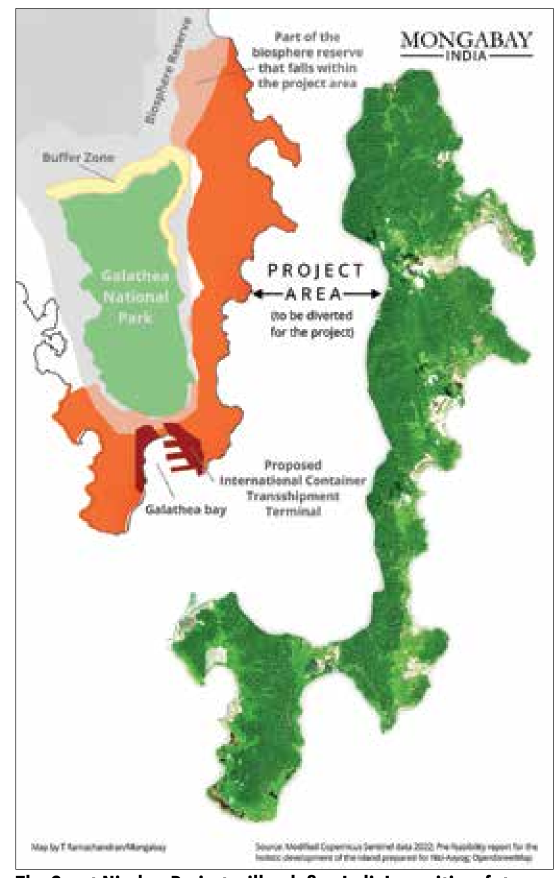
THE WRITER IS A MEMBER OF THE NATIONAL EXECUTIVE COMMITTEE (NEC), BJP, AND THE CHAIRMAN OF DR SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE RESEARCH FOUNDATION

The Congress party has a record of neglecting India's strategic needs. Nehru's infamous pampering of Krishna Menon and his neglect of India's frontier, along with his looking the other way while Pakistan encouraged China to gobble up the Aksai Chin region, though well-known, require periodic reiteration and assertion. Indira Gandhi bartered away our gains after she was duped by Bhutto at the infamous "Simla Conference" into surrendering India's strategic vantage.

Writing in his *Nehru: The Lotus Eater from Kashmir (1953)*, D.F. Karaka (1911–1974), the well-known journalist who covered the Nehru era, argued that Nehru's neutrality implied, among other things, the "denial of any form of preparation for any eventuality, or any training for participation in any future conflict, other than required for guarding of our frontier with Pakistan." Militarily, Karaka pointed out, "India's prime concern is to be a little stronger than Pakistan, but no more." Describing the mindset of the Nehruvian era, Karaka wrote, "It is now officially accepted in India that Mao has no territorial ambition outside his own frontiers. The highly militarised manoeuvres of Chinese troops along and behind the Brahmaputra River, which the Chinese prefer to call the Tsangpo, have to be written off as P.T. exercise…"

Eventually, everyone came to see the effects of Nehru's neutrality on India's defence and strategic options. Karaka pithily summed it up when he wrote that it had "brought one of the most dangerous enemies of democracy right on to our northern gates, while Pandit Nehru sleeps the soft slumber of innocence, exchanging goodwill missions with the Chinese." Karaka wrote this in 1953; the effects of this neutrality and neglect hit India in October 1962. Nehru never recovered from that blow. The Chinese attack also exposed the over-decade-long neglect to which India's defence had been subjected.

India's gains in 1971 were squandered away when Indira Gandhi, trying to act as the elder statesman, gave in to Bhutto's confessions and professions of good behaviour. Pakistan's hand in the Mujib assassination in 1975, and the reversal of India's fortunes in the region within a few years of such a massive military victory, are part of recorded history. For decades after that, it became a habit with Congress dispensations in Delhi to continue their neglect of border infrastructure and strategic imperatives.



The Great Nicobar Project will redefine India's maritime future

> The Great Nicobar Project is not merely an infrastructure initiative. It is India's strategic declaration in the Indo-Pacific

Speaking in the Lok Sabha in September 2013, then Union Defence Minister and senior Congress leader A.K. Antony made a strange confession when he said that the post-Independence policy decision was that undeveloped borders were the best defence, and that is why there were no roads and infrastructure along the border, while China continued to build infrastructure along its side of the border. At the fag end of the Congress era, in 2013, Antony confessed that this policy was being reversed. The complete reversal of that policy was left to Narendra Modi, who, on becoming Prime Minister, made the development of border infrastructure one of the priority areas of his government.

Seen against this backdrop, it is not surprising to see Congress leader Rahul Gandhi oppose the strategically vital and game-changing Great Nicobar Project. In the case of Rahul Gandhi, his concern for the environment is only a veneer to camouflage his willing collaboration with external forces that remain inimical to India's strategic interests and progress. Over the years, Rahul Gandhi has acted as an active agent of these forces, especially when it concerned India's diplomatic and strategic interests. In opposing the Great Nicobar Project, the Congress is deliberately opposing the strengthening of India's economic, maritime, and defence capabilities. It is trying to stall a major initiative that will serve India's long-term strategic interests and make it a major player in the Indian Ocean Region, the Malacca Strait region, and beyond.

Before discussing the centrality of the Great Nicobar Project, let us examine the Congress government's disastrous track record in rehabilitation after the 2004 tsunami that struck the islands. Nicobar Island was flattened in the aftermath of the 2004 tsunami, with over 90 per cent of its houses destroyed and hundreds of families washed away. Over 6,000 people died or went missing.

The rehabilitation drive undertaken from Delhi by the UPA government was another disaster, marked by poor housing quality, the ignoring of decisions made by tribal heads, confusion over land rights, and the undermining of self-governance structures. Rahul Gandhi, then a Member of Parliament, did not show concern for the rights and sensitivities of tribes in Nicobar.

Between 1969 and 1980, long before the tsunami, the Congress government had settled 330 families in seven villages, with each family allotted 11 acres of land. To connect these settlements, two principal arterial roads were laid through dense tropical forests, rupturing the fragile ecosystem that had upheld the Shompen ecosystem for millennia. One was the 51-km north-south corridor and the other a 43-km east-west corridor. If successive Congress governments had done this for national security in the past, how is the national security angle missing from the Congress's understanding of the project today?

In 1985, Rahul's late father, Rajiv Gandhi, had proposed opening parts of the islands to Indian and non-resident industrialists and had planned to set up over 2,000 industries over the years. Rahul must have been conscious enough then to protest against his father's proposed destruction of the pristine forests of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands. Rajiv Gandhi had also proposed developing the Andaman and Nicobar Islands as a free port rivalling Singapore and Hong Kong, including the creation of a tax haven. Rajiv's proposal also included cultivating red oil palm over 15,000 hectares, which entailed the destruction of precious forest cover.

The Congress, thus, is behaving hypocritically in its opposition to the strategically vital Nicobar project. In 2004, the Congress-led UPA government, of which the Left was a major constituent, had decided to lease islands like Havelock, Cinque, Little Andaman, Ross Island, South Andaman, and other islands to international private players. It was during the Congress-UPA's ten years in power that China was allowed to weave its "String of Pearls" network without a counter-push or strategy.

The Modi government has been pursuing this vital strategic project since 2019. It was first conceived by the NITI Aayog as a "mega development" plan for a strategic economic and military hub in the Indo-Pacific. In March 2021, the Modi government formally launched the project under the Andaman and Nicobar Islands Integrated Development Corporation (ANIIDCO), and by November 2021, the project was fast-tracked, receiving Stage-I forest clearance for the diversion of 130.75 sq km of land, along with final environmental clearance.

While the Congress remained silent when the project was mooted, its international proxies have now been activated. International NGOs such as Survival International came out with reports against the project, while former bureaucrats were activated to oppose it in courts. Surprisingly, a group like the Constitutional Crisis Group, supposedly manned by seasoned former diplomats and bureaucrats like Shiv Shankar Menon, a former NSA, S.Y. Qureshi, and the usual suspects like Aruna Roy, came out in opposition to the project.

International "genocide experts", whatever that means, led by the likes of Mark Levene, Raz Segal, Dirk Moses, Thomas Kuehne et al., wrote a "genocide letter" opposing the project. This letter became the principal weapon that the Congress leadership, with Jairam Ramesh in the fray, wielded against the project. Once again, the Congress invited international attention to a project that is vitally Indian and pertains to India's strategic interests. The other usual suspects — Harsh Mander, Nandini Sundar, and Ashish Kothari — all representing a cabal of a well-oiled NGO network, began opposing the project. Obviously, the question that arises is: at whose behest are these people, fanboys of the Congress, opposing the project, and at whose behest is the Congress opposing the project?

The Great Nicobar Project is vital for India's next-generation strategic leap. In an increasingly complex and volatile international scenario, the project, once completed in phases by 2047, will enable India to monitor and influence maritime traffic, activities, and events across the world's most critical sea lanes. It will enable India to strengthen, expand, and assert its maritime sphere of influence and capabilities, eventually transforming the country into a major player in the Indian Ocean, the Indo-Pacific, and the Far East. The project will also enable a deepening of maritime integration with other Indian ports such as Chennai, Haldia, Visakhapatnam, Paradip, Kochi, and Mundra, to name a few, leading to a more cohesive domestic-to-global shipping network.

In short, the Great Nicobar Project will propel India towards what it once was civilisationally — a major maritime power. Why would the Congress and its ecosystem desperately want to prevent that? Perhaps because it has already surrendered itself to, and been co-opted by, elements and ideologies that want to stymie the rise of India as a civilisational state.

Views expressed are personal

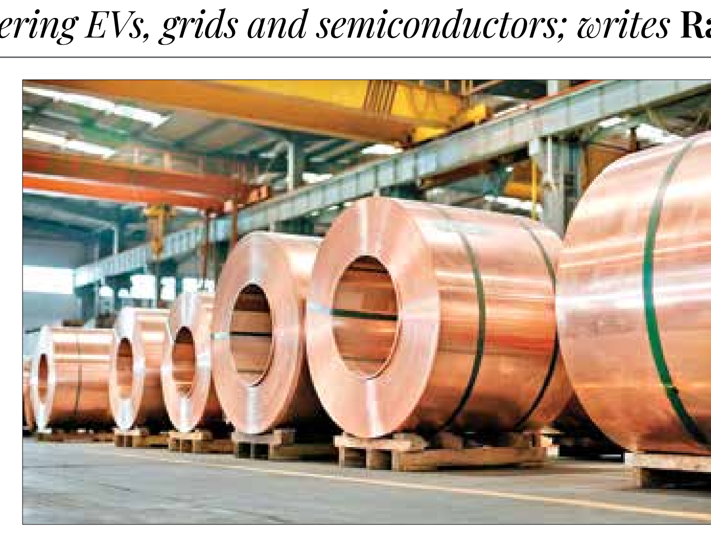
PM Modi's Copper Warning

As global conflicts disrupt supply chains, India faces growing strategic dependence on copper, the critical metal powering EVs, grids and semiconductors; writes **Ravikumar Ramanujam**

The wars India watches from a distance are now beginning to shape the choices it makes at home. With the Strait of Hormuz crisis disrupting energy flows and commodity markets turning volatile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi used his Secunderabad speech this week to deliver an unusually direct message: India can no longer afford strategic dependence. Alongside calls to reduce fuel consumption and unnecessary gold purchases, he pointed to a less discussed vulnerability, copper. He noted that India is now spending precious foreign exchange importing a metal it once produced domestically.

That warning about copper deserves far more attention than it has received amid the wider focus on Modi's remarks about fuel consumption and imports.

Copper is no longer just an industrial metal. It is the backbone of the energy transition. Electric vehicles use far more copper than conventional automobiles. Solar plants, wind turbines, power grids, battery storage systems and data centers are all copper intensive. Every ambition India has announced, from renewable energy expansion to semiconductor manufacturing, depends on reliable access to copper.



Copper is no longer just an industrial metal. It is the backbone of the energy transition

> PM Modi's remarks signalled a larger shift in thinking — that India's economic sovereignty and clean energy ambitions cannot survive on imported critical metals

Yet India's copper story over the last few years has been one of decline. The country, once a net exporter of refined copper, has turned into a net importer after the closure of the Vedanta-owned Sterlite Copper Plant in Thoothukudi in 2018. The plant alone accounted for nearly 40 per cent of India's copper smelting capacity. Its shutdown did not reduce India's demand for copper. It merely shifted dependence outward.

The numbers reflect the cost of that decision. Government data showed that refined copper imports rose from 44,245 tonnes in 2017-18 to 92,290 tonnes in 2018-19 after the plant's closure, while exports sharply declined. India, which had recorded net exports of over 3.3 lakh tonnes earlier, moved into a net import position within a year.

India's copper imports have risen sharply over the years, even as global competition for critical minerals intensifies. Industry estimates suggest domestic demand could more than double by 2030 due to electrification and infrastructure growth. Meanwhile, countries across the world are aggressively securing supply chains for critical minerals and industrial metals and increasingly treating them as strategic assets rather than ordinary commodities.

At the same time, the debate around copper production in India has also evolved. Discussions around the possible restart of Sterlite are now increasingly centered on whether India can build a modern, globally competitive and environmentally sustainable copper ecosystem. Recent proposals placed before the Madras High Court for a green copper restart have emphasised upgraded emission controls, tighter hazardous waste protocols, expanded desalination and water recycling systems, independent third-party audits and greater community oversight mechanisms.

Modi's remarks in Secunderabad suggested an attempt to shift that conversation. He framed the issue not just as an industrial concern but as a broader question of national priorities. Referring to the shutdown of copper plants and the resulting import dependence, he urged labour groups and industrial stakeholders to ensure that disruptions do not come at the cost of India's long-term strategic interests and self-reliance.

This is why the Prime Minister's comments matter. They reflect a growing recognition within the government that self-reliance cannot stop at slogans about manufacturing. It must extend to the raw materials that make manufacturing possible in the first place.

Reopening Sterlite would not merely be about restarting a plant. It would signal that India is finally willing to treat copper as a strategic sector. Atmanirbhar Bharat cannot coexist with rising dependence on imported critical metals.

For years, India's self-reliance debate has focused on finished products. The next phase will be decided by whether the country can secure the resources underneath them. Copper sits at the center of that challenge. And increasingly, at the center of India's economic future.

The writer is a senior journalist and columnist. Views expressed are personal

UK POLITICAL CRISIS

Wes Streeting of Labour Party wants to be Britain's next PM

LONDON: Wes Streeting's ambition to head the British government was one of the worst-kept secrets in UK politics.

But if anyone was unaware, it's now official — the former health secretary announced on Saturday his intention to oust Prime Minister Keir Starmer.

Streeting is the first member of Parliament to say he will take on Starmer in what is likely to be a bruising internal contest for the reins of the Labour Party, which has seen its fortunes fall in the two years since its historic landslide victory swept out Conservatives after 14 years in power.

Streeting is likely to face other challengers, including Greater Manchester Mayor Andy Burnham, if the latter can win a special election for a

Wes Streetin

seat in the House of Commons.

Starmer has vowed to fight on despite being widely unpopular after a series of setbacks, policy U-turns and questions over his judgment for appointing a friend of the sex offender Jeffrey Epstein as US ambassador. The government is facing weeks of chaos after it rejected calls to resign following the party's disastrous results in the May 7 local and regional UK elections, in which Nigel Farage's anti-immigrant Reform UK made huge gains.

Highlights

- » Streeting is likely to face other challengers, including Greater Manchester Mayor Andy Burnham
- » Starmer has vowed to fight on despite being widely unpopular after a series of setbacks
- » The govt is facing weeks of chaos after it rejected calls to resign

"The voters did more than send Labour a message last week," Streeting said on Saturday.

"They issued a warning: that unless we change course, we risk being the handmaidens of Nigel Farage and the breakup of the United Kingdom."

The boyish-looking Streeting, 43, is widely regarded as one of the party's best communicators and has been an outspoken voice on issues that include the war in Gaza.

His rise in the ranks of the Labour Party from roots in London's working-class East End, where he grew up in public housing, is charted in his memoir, "One Boy, Two Bills and a Fry Up: A Memoir of Growing Up and Getting On."

The title refers to two grandfathers, both named Bill: The one on his mother's side was associated with gangsters and served prison time for armed robbery; he credits the one on his father's side with leading him on the path to Cambridge University. AGENCIES

Ukrainian drone strikes on Russia kill 4, wound 12 others

KYIV: One of Ukraine's largest drone strikes on Russia killed at least four people, including three near Moscow, and wounded a dozen others, local authorities said Sunday. Debris fell on Russia's largest airport without causing damage.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy confirmed the drone strikes, saying that they were "entirely justified".

Russia has repeatedly launched similar attacks on Ukraine's capital and other cities during the war, and an expert said that the strikes appeared to be retaliation for recent Russian attacks on Kyiv.

Russian drone strikes on Ukraine overnight wounded eight people, Ukrainian authorities said.

In Ukraine's strikes on Russia, a woman was killed after a drone hit her home in Khimki, a Russian city just northwest of Moscow, and two men died in the village of Pogorelki, which is 10 kilometers (6 miles) north of the capital, according to local Gov. Andrei Vorobyev.

Russia has repeatedly launched similar attacks on Ukraine's capital and other cities during the war AP/PTI

> ONE MAN WAS KILLED AFTER A DRONE STRUCK A TRUCK IN THE BELGOROD REGION

Ukrainian drones had also damaged unspecified "infrastructure" and several high-rise buildings, Vorobyev said on social media. One man was also killed after a drone struck a truck in the Belgorod region, which borders Ukraine, according to local authorities.

In Moscow itself, at least 12 people were wounded in the nighttime strike, mostly near the entrance to the city's oil refinery, mayor Sergei Sobyanin reported. Sobyanin reported that the "technology" of the refinery hadn't been damaged. AGENCIES

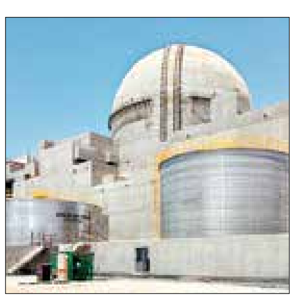
SHAKES IRAN WAR CEASEFIRE

Drone strike causes fire outside nuclear power plant in Abu Dhabi

DUBAI: A drone strike targeted the United Arab Emirates' sole nuclear power plant on Sunday, sparking a fire on its perimeter. There were no reports of injuries or radiological release, but it highlighted the risk of renewed war as the Iran ceasefire remains tenuous.

No one immediately claimed responsibility, and the UAE did not blame anyone. It has, however, accused Iran of launching multiple drone and missile attacks in recent days as tensions have risen over the Strait of Hormuz, a vital energy waterway that Iran still has in a chokehold.

The United States is blockading Iranian ports, and diplomatic efforts aimed at a more durable peace have repeatedly faltered. The UAE has meanwhile hosted air defences and personnel from Israel, which joined the US in the Feb. 28 attack that sparked the war.



US President Donald Trump has suggested hostilities could resume, and Iranian state television has repeatedly aired segments with anchors holding Kalashnikov-style rifles in an effort to prepare the public for war. Fighting has also heated up between Israel and the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon despite a nominal ceasefire there, further straining the wider truce.

The USD 20 billion Barakah nuclear power plant was built by the UAE with the help of South Korea and went online in 2020. It is the first and only nuclear power plant in the Arab world and can provide a quarter of all the energy needs in the UAE, a federation of seven sheikhdoms. The UAE's nuclear regulator said the fire didn't affect plant safety. "All units are operating as normal," the organisation wrote on X.

The UAE statement didn't blame any party for the attack. The Vienna-based International Atomic Energy Agency, the United Nations' nuclear watchdog, said the strike caused a fire in an electrical generator and that one reactor was being powered by emergency diesel generators. IAEA director-general Rafael Mariano Grossi expressed "grave concern" about the incident and said military activity that threatens nuclear safety is unacceptable, the agency said in a statement. AGENCIES

Indian killed in drone attack on Moscow

MOSCOW: An Indian worker was killed and three others injured in a drone attack in the Moscow region, the Indian embassy said Sunday.

The incident comes amid escalating hostilities between Russia and Ukraine. Ukraine carried out overnight attacks targeting installations in Moscow.

"One Indian worker has lost his life and three others have been injured in a drone attack in (the) Moscow region earlier today. Embassy officials have visited the location and met the injured workers in the hospital," the Indian Embassy in Russia said on 'X'.

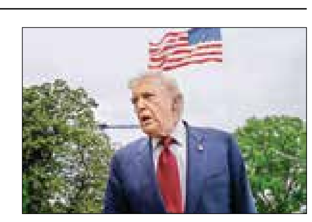
"The Embassy condoles the loss of life and is working with the company management and local authorities to provide necessary assistance to the workers," it said. AGENCIES

Trump, South Korea's Lee discuss outcome of US-China summit

SEOUL: South Korean President Lee Jae Myung and U.S. President Donald Trump held a phone call on Sunday and discussed the outcome of the U.S.-China summit meeting, the South Korean Blue House presidential office said in a statement on Sunday.

Trump shared \with Lee results of his meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping, including U.S.-China relations, agreements over economic and trade issues and Korean affairs, as well as the situation in the Middle East, the Blue House said. The Korean president found Trump and Xi had constructive talks over affairs on the Korean Peninsula, it said.

Trump told Lee that Trump would contribute to peace and stability on the Korean Peninsula through close cooperation with South Korea, according to the Blue House. Lee told Trump



US President Donald Trump

that the stable management of U.S.-China relations would contribute to peace and prosperity in the region and the world. He also expressed his hope to Trump for instant recovery of peace and stability in the Middle East, it said. The two leaders also talked about the smooth implementation of a bilateral trade deal signed last year, the statement added.

China came out ahead, given the retreat from the Trump administration's brash approach on trade from early 2025, said Scott Kennedy. AGENCIES

Israel to establish defence offices in Jerusalem

JERUSALEM: Israel's cabinet on Sunday approved a plan to build a defence compound on the site of the recently demolished premises of the United Nations Relief and Works Agency in East Jerusalem.

Israel in January demolished structures inside the U.N. Palestinian refugee agency's East Jerusalem compound after seizing the site last year, in an act condemned by the agency as a violation of international law.

In a joint statement, the Defence Ministry and Jerusalem Municipality said the new compound would include the establishment of a military museum, a recruitment office and a defence minister's office.

Defence Minister Israel Katz called the decision one of "sovereignty, Zionism, and security."

UNRWA, which Israeli authorities accuse of bias, had not used the building since the start of last year after Israel ordered it to vacate all its premises and cease its operations.

A UNRWA spokesperson declined to comment on the Israeli plan.

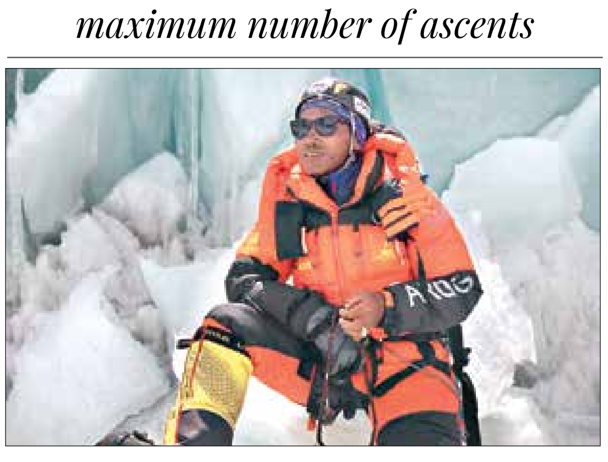
The agency operates in East Jerusalem, which the U.N. and most countries consider territory occupied by Israel as it was captured from Jordan in the 1967 Middle East war. Israel considers all Jerusalem to be its indivisible capital.w

UNRWA also operates in Gaza, the West Bank and elsewhere in the Middle East, providing schooling, healthcare, social services and shelter to millions of Palestinians.

"There is nothing more symbolic or justified than establishing the new IDF recruitment office and defence establishment institutions precisely on the ruins of the former UNRWA compound — an organization whose employees took part in the massacres, murders, and atrocities committed by Hamas terrorists on October 7," Katz said. AGENCIES

Nepal's mountaineer Kami Rita Sherpa climbs Mt Everest for 32nd time

Breaks his own world record for the maximum number of ascents



Nepal's mountaineer Kami Rita

KATHMANDU: Nepal's mountaineer Kami Rita Sherpa made history on Sunday by breaking his own world record for the maximum number of ascents of Mt Everest as he scaled the world's highest peak for the 32nd time.

The 56-year-old veteran climber, popularly known as 'Everest Man', reached the 8,848.86-metre peak (29,032 feet) at 10:12 am, according to the Department of Tourism here. He was leading an expedition operated by 14 Peaks Expedition, it said.

The successful ascent was confirmed by the department's field office stationed at Everest Base Camp, reported The Kathmandu Post.

Born in Thame village of Solukhumbu district in Koshi Province in January 1970, Kami Rita started his career as a professional mountaineer in 1992 and climbed Mt Everest for the first time in 1994.

The Department of Tourism congratulated Sherpa, saying his achievement reflects a significant contribution to Nepal's mountaineering sector and its international profile.

Kami Rita had climbed Sagarmatha, as the peak is known in Nepali, twice each in 2023 and 2024. He scaled it for the 31st time on May 27, 2025, said.

Between 1994 and 2025, Kami Rita also scaled K2 and Mt Lhotse once, Manaslu thrice, and Cho Oyu eight times, all above 8,000 metres.

In a related development, Lhakpa Sherpa, also known as the 'Mountain Queen' and the first Nepali woman to summit Mt Everest, broke her own world record by completing her 11th successful ascent of the peak on Sunday.

She reached the peak at 9:30 am, the Department of Tourism said.

Prime Minister Balendra Shah congratulated them and said, "Such historic success can only be achieved through unwavering courage, rigorous self-discipline, and honest dedication to one's work."

Mt Everest, Shah said in a post on X, "is not merely a geographical elevation; it is the supreme symbol of Nepal's self-respect, courage, patience, and Himalayan civilisation. On this glorious mountain today, Nepali climbers have once again written history." AGENCIES

'Pak Interior Minister's Tehran visit linked to reviving Iran-US talks'

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi's previously unannounced visit to Tehran was linked by Pakistani and Iranian media to Islamabad's continuing efforts to revive the stalled Iran-US peace process amid persistent tensions in West Asia.

Dawn newspaper, quoting unnamed diplomatic sources, reported on Sunday that Naqvi's two-day visit came after US President Donald Trump rejected Tehran's latest response to American proposals.

It also said that Pakistan was continuing shuttle diplomacy aimed at preventing the negotiations from collapsing entirely after momentum generated by earlier rounds of talks in Islamabad slowed sharply.

Iran's semi-official Tasnim News Agency also described Naqvi's trip as part of Pakistan's "ongoing efforts to facilitate dialogue and promote regional peace".

The visit, officially framed around bilateral and border security cooperation, came as the fragile ceasefire brokered earlier through Pakistani mediation continued to hold unevenly amid intermittent tensions around the Strait of Hormuz and prolonged disruption to global energy shipping.

> Naqvi, who arrived in Tehran on Saturday, is expected to hold meetings with senior Iranian officials during the visit to cover both bilateral security matters and the wider regional situation

Naqvi, who arrived in Tehran on Saturday, is expected to hold meetings with senior Iranian officials during the visit to cover both bilateral security matters and the wider regional situation. He met his Iranian counterpart Eskandar Momeni soon after landing.

According to Tasnim News Agency, the two interior ministers discussed Iran-Pakistan relations, regional developments and "the prospects for the resumption of peace negotiations" between Iran and the US.

Iran's official news agency IRNA reported that the two sides also discussed border trade, transit, exchange of goods and bilateral cooperation, while describing the recent high-level contacts between Tehran and Islamabad as part of intensified consultations following the Pakistan-mediated ceasefire.

The visit came hot on the heels of Trump's trip to Beijing and his meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping, which produced no visible breakthrough on the ongoing conflict despite speculation beforehand that Beijing could quietly encourage Tehran toward compromise.

Analysts noted that Trump returned from Beijing still publicly emphasising coercive leverage, while simultaneously indicating limited flexibility on enrichment timelines.

Speaking to reporters aboard Air Force One, Trump said he could accept a 20-year suspension of Iran's nuclear activity if they provided what he described as a "real" guarantee, appearing to signal some flexibility from Washington's earlier demands for a permanent end of Iran's nuclear programme. AGENCIES

Demand for cruises appears undimmed despite hantavirus, other onboard outbreaks

Recent outbreaks of hantavirus on cruise ships are making headlines

NEW YORK: Recent outbreaks of hantavirus and norovirus on cruise ships are making headlines, but they're unlikely to dim the growing popularity of vacation cruises, according to industry representatives and travel experts.

In fact, many within the industry still expect a record number of people worldwide to take cruises this year despite three passengers aboard the MV Hondius dying from hantavirus after the ship stopped in Argentina and a recent norovirus outbreak aboard a British ship docked in Bordeaux, France.

"The cruise consumer seems to be somewhat Teflon when it comes to stories like this," said Rob Kwortnik, an associate professor at Cornell University's Nolan School of Hotel Administration who closely watches the cruise industry. In mid-April, an annual forecast by the Cruise Lines International Association, an industry trade group, estimated that 38.3 million people would travel on ocean-going ships this year, 4 per cent

Takeaways

- » Veteran cruisegoers said the outbreak would not affect their plans
- » Industrywide sales figures are closely held
- » Several big cruise companies didn't respond to questions from mediqa about customer demand, including Royal Caribbean, Norwegian and Carnivawl

more from a record 37.2 million passengers last year.

Industrywide sales figures are closely held. Asked about potential impacts from what happened aboard the MV Hondius, the trade association said it doesn't comment or speculate on bookings. Several big cruise companies didn't respond to questions from The Associated Press about customer demand, including Royal Caribbean, Norwegian and Carnival.

Oceanwide Expeditions, the Dutch company that owns the MV Hondius, said it doesn't foresee any changes to its operations. It has a cruise setting sail from Keflavik, Iceland, on May 29. Veteran cruisegoers said the outbreak would not affect their plans. "I have eight cruises booked, and I'll absolutely be booking another," said Jenni Fielding, who blogs and posts social media videos about cruise trips under the moniker Cruise Mummy. "Cruising is as safe as any other type of holiday, provided travellers follow sensible health advice and stay aware of official guidance."

Scott Eddy, a hospitality influencer, is currently on a cruise and docked in Monaco. Fellow passengers have not mentioned the hantavirus outbreak, he said. "The average traveller understands that this is an isolated health situation and not something unique to cruise travel itself," Eddy said.

CruiseCompete.com, an online marketplace where consumers making vacation plans can compare offers from travel agents, booked 31.7 per cent more cruises in the first half of May compared to the same period last year, CEO Bob Levinstein said. AGENCIES

World Briefs

PAKISTAN'S KHYBER PAKHTUNKHWA GOVERNMENT EXPANDS CABINET

PESHAWAR: Five new ministers, four advisors and eight special assistants were inducted in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa government on Sunday, an official statement said. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Governor Faisal Karim Kundi administered the oath to newly appointed provincial ministers during a ceremony held at the Governor's House here. According to the official statement, the ministers who took oath included Shafi Jan, Shakeel Ahmad, Tariq Mahmood, Nazir Abbasi and Arif Ahmadzai. However, lawmaker Adnan Qadri, who was also nominated as a minister, could not take the oath as he is abroad.

TRAIN DRIVER CHARGED AFTER DEADLY CRASH IN THAILAND

BANGKOK: Thai police have charged a train driver with negligence after a crash on Saturday in central Bangkok in which a freight train collided with a public bus at a rail crossing, killing eight people and injuring 32. "The train driver has been charged with negligence causing death, as evidence clearly indicates reckless conduct leading to fatalities," Urumporn Koondejsumrit, head of the Makkasan Police Station, told Reuters. He said the bus driver would also be charged, but remained under medical treatment and could not be questioned, so charges had not yet been filed. Investigators are examining whether additional charges may be brought, he said.

Prudential to buy 75% stake in Bharti Life for ₹3,500 cr

Currently, Prudential is a partner with ICICI Bank with around 22 per cent stake in the life insurance venture

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: UK-based Prudential plc on Sunday announced to acquire a majority 75 per cent stake in Bharti Life Insurance for Rs 3,500 crore from Bharti Life Ventures Pvt Ltd and 360 ONE Asset Management.

Currently, Prudential is a partner with ICICI Bank with around 22 per cent stake in the life insurance venture. With the announcement of a majority stake in Bharti Life Insurance, Prudential has to pare back its stake in the existing venture to comply with regulatory requirements. This is the second exit from a long-standing foreign insurance venture partner, following Allianz's exit from Bajaj Finserve last year. The transaction is for an initial cash consideration of Rs 3,500 crore payable on completion, Prudential Plc said in a statement.

With announcement of a majority stake in Bharti Life Insurance, Prudential has to pare back its stake in existing venture to comply with regulatory requirements

Highlights

» This is the 2nd exit from a long-standing foreign insurance venture partner, following Allianz's exit from Bajaj Finserve last year

» The transaction will be funded from existing resources. It is likely to deliver compelling strategic and financial benefits for Prudential over time

» It is expected that part of proceeds from any divestment of ICICIPru Life will be used to support future growth

"The transaction will be funded from existing resources. The transaction is expected to deliver compelling strategic and financial benefits for Prudential over time. Further details will be provided when regulatory consent has been received for the transaction. It is expected that part of the proceeds from any divestment of ICICIPru Life will be used to support future growth in the business," it said.

The residual capital would contribute to Prudential's free surplus, it said, adding that there is potential additional consideration payable of up to Rs 700 crore, dependent on the fulfilment of certain conditions.

Sunil Bharti Mittal, Chairman, Bharti Enterprises, said, "Prudential's experience and global scale, combined with Bharti's strong track record, create a formidable alliance to tap into the immense potential of India's life insurance sector. This partnership opens new opportunities for Bharti Life's employees and further reinforces the strategic relationship between India and the UK.

Following completion, Prudential's Indian operations will consist of majority-owned Bharti Life Insurance Company Limited and Prudential HCL Health Insurance Limited, and minority shareholdings in two listed entities, namely 35 per cent of ICICI Prudential Asset Management Company Limited and 22 per cent in ICICI Prudential Life Insurance Company. Regulatory approvals for the transaction are expected to require Prudential to reduce its shareholding in ICICI Pru Life to under 10 per cent, it said.

Prudential is engaging with the relevant regulatory authorities on this process and will seek an appropriate timeframe for the divestment that may be required, in the interests of its shareholders, it said.

Separately, it said, Prudential continues to progress toward regulatory approvals for its standalone, majority-owned health insurance business in India. Health insurance operations are expected to commence during 2026 on receipt of these approvals. "India is a strategically important and exciting market for Prudential. By acquiring a controlling stake in Bharti Life, we are bringing together Prudential's nearly 180 years of global insurance expertise and Bharti's strong and growing local presence to serve the savings and protection needs of Indian consumers," Prudential plc's CEO Anil Wadhwani said.

Ambuja Cements slashes FY27 capex to ₹6,500 cr, prioritises project completion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Ambuja Cements has acknowledged a delay in the execution of expansion projects and said it is keeping its capital expenditure (capex) in FY27 "moderate" in the range of Rs 6,000-6,500 crore as against Rs 7,500 crore last year as it focuses on completion rather than taking on new ones.

Ambuja Cement Director Karan Adani, while replying to a query in a post-earnings investor call, admitted that execution in the cement business has fallen short of the group's standards due to contractor issues, a lack of an execution team, and incomplete engineering work.

The country's second-largest cement maker is "pausing and correcting" itself and "wants to first complete our projects that we have taken in our hand before we start any new projects", Karan Adani said.

Among the key reasons for delays was the selection of contractors that did not meet execution expectations.

"We did not choose the right contractor for execution," said Karan Adani, adding that the company had also faced challenges in building a capable project execution team after acquiring Ambuja Cements and ACC.

Besides, the Adani Group also faced challenges after acquiring ACC and Ambuja as there was no ready execution team in place, requiring time to build capabilities internally.

Ambuja Cement Director Karan Adani

Further, several projects were initiated before full engineering plans had been completed, he said, adding that the company is now using a six-month period to complete engineering work for proposed projects before starting execution.

"So, we are using the six months to complete all our engineering for the new projects that we are thinking of starting. And once that is in place, then we will be looking at starting the project," Adani said, adding that he is "confident" that "at least now we will be able to complete these projects in the time line that were given".

Replying to a query on future expansion strategy, Adani said while the company continues to evaluate inorganic opportunities, its primary focus remains on organic growth and greenfield expansion.

"Inorganically, we keep evaluating, but our focus right now is on organic development and greenfield expansion. That is our number one priority," he said.

Ambuja Cements CEO Vindo Behety, who was also on the investors' call said the turnaround initiatives have taken a little longer than the expected time lines, resulting in elevated costs.

"And some of these plants, especially of Penna, needed higher than expected time for maintenance capex and overall upkeep of the assets. So on a cost front, we have seen a bit of higher cost compared to our own expectations and therefore, some disappointments," said Behety.

Operational breakdowns, which were largely concentrated in acquired assets, particularly at Penna Industries and Sanghi plants, where the company has seen major disruptions.

He said higher repair and maintenance (R&M) costs during the year were partly due to overdue maintenance work that had not been undertaken earlier, contributing to breakdowns at the facilities. The company's teams are currently focused on improving plant reliability at these acquired units, he added.

The Adani Group, the country's second-largest cement manufacturer, crossed the 100 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) capacity milestone in record time -- largely driven by acquisitions -- and has set an ambitious target to expand capacity to 140 MTPA by FY28, primarily through brownfield expansion projects.

The group has witnessed delays of three to six months in some of its efficiency-focused capex projects, though the company expects execution momentum to improve in the coming quarters, Behety added.

"And hopefully, like in coming quarter, we should be gaining momentum to complete and get the benefits of it. So, therefore, in FY27, our focus firmly remains on streamlining the operations and margin expansion," he said.

In FY26, Adani's cement capacity increased to 109 MTPA, which was supported by commissioning of 10.7 million tonnes of new grinding capacity at various locations like Marwar, Farakka, Sankrail, Sindri, Krishnapatnam, and the additional clinker capacity of 7 million tonnes at Jodhpur and Bhatapar, he said.

"We are expecting to hit capacity of almost 119 million tonnes by end of FY27," he added.

Adani Group, a new entrant in the cement sector, jumped into the cement sector in September 2022, after acquiring controlling stakes in Ambuja Cement from Swiss firm Holcim for cash proceeds of $6.4 billion (about Rs 51,000 crore).

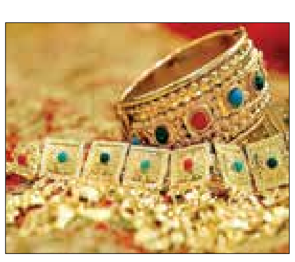
Ambuja Cements, which owns a 51 per cent stake in ACC Ltd, pursued inorganic growth, acquiring small companies as Hyderabad-based Penna Cement and Saurashtra-based Sanghi Industries. Earlier this year, it also acquired Orient Cement from the CK Birla group.

India's gems and jewellery exports falls 9.07% in April to $2,226.45 mn

MUMBAI: India's gems and jewellery exports declined by 9.07 per cent at $2,226.45 million (Rs 20,825.01 crore) in April following the West Asia conflict, the Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council said.

The total exports were $2,448.53 million (Rs 20,952.26 crore) in the same month in 2025, as per the data by the industry apex body GJEPC.

"Decline in exports is mainly due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, which has caused worldwide disruptions affecting exports. Besides geopolitical tensions, exports to the US, a major export market for the gems and jewellery industry, were also affected because there is still no clarity on the tariffs," GJEPC Chairman Kirit Bhansali said.



Total exports were $2,448.53 million (Rs 20,952.26 crore) in the same month in 2025

Meanwhile, data from the GJEPC revealed that the overall export of cut and polished diamonds declined 19.65 per cent in April at $890.91 million compared to $1,108.74 million for the same period last year.

Export of polished lab-grown diamonds dipped 15.53 per cent to $93.28 million in April from $110.43 million last year.

Gold jewellery exports was down 21.77 per cent to $841.54 million in April, compared to $1,075.67 million for the same period last year.

The total export of plain gold jewellery at $341.08 in April 2026 showing a decline of 47.06 per cent against $644.33 for the same period of the previous year.

However, the exports of studded gold jewellery grew 16.02 per cent at $500.46 in April compared to $431.35 for the same period last year.

Silver jewellery exports in the previous month surged by 444 per cent to $268.38 million against $49.33 million in the same month last year. PTI

Gautam Adani performs 'bhumi pujan' for 2 eye care facilities in Bihar's Saran district

PATNA: Business tycoon Gautam Adani on Sunday performed groundbreaking ceremonies for a couple of eye care facilities in Bihar's Saran district that would have the capacity to perform up to 3.3 lakh surgeries annually and provide training to 1,000 professionals.

The Adani Group chairman and his wife, Priti Adani, who heads the Adani Foundation, performed 'bhoomi pujan' for the Adani Centre for Eye Diseases and Adani Training Centre for Ophthalmic Sciences.

Both these facilities will be attached to the Akhand Jyoti Eye Hospital at Mastichak, about 70 km from the state capital.

Mrityunjay Tiwari, the chief executive officer of the Akhand Jyoti Trust, a non-profit organisation that runs the hospital, was also present on the occasion.

According to a statement issued by the Adani Group, Rs 150 crore has been pledged by Adani Foundation, the CSR arm of the business conglomerate, for the two projects.

Speaking on this occasion, Gautam Adani said he believed in the philosophy of "seva hi sadhana hai" (service is worship) and announced a "personal commitment of Rs 500 crore" to the non-profit Akhand Jyoti Foundation, to boost "long-term humanitarian and community health care mission across the country".

The Adani Akhand Jyoti Foundation shall "expand affordable vision care and community health care access beyond Bihar across underserved regions in India", the statement issued by the business conglomerate said.

It also said the Adani Foundation will establish a 200-bed hospital in Pirpainti, near the Adani Group's upcoming ultra-supercritical 2,400 MW thermal power plant in Bihar's Bhagalpur district, which is to be built at an estimated cost of Rs 27,000 crore.

In a post on X, Gautam Adani described Bihar as "a land that has historically given the nation a new consciousness and direction."

"Adani Akhand Jyoti Foundation would seek to take the spirit of service born in Bihar to underserved communities across India," he said. MPOST

Hero MotoCorp earmarks ₹1,500 crore capex for FY27

NEW DELHI: Two-wheeler market leader Hero MotoCorp has earmarked Rs 1,500 crore capex for FY27 to double its scooter production capacity, its CEO Harshavardhan Chitale said.

The company has also committed over Rs 700 crore of investment in building a global parts centre in South of India, he told analysts.

"We are investing in capacity expansion, and we have committed over Rs 1,500 crore of capex in FY27. And this capex is going to expand our capacity in scooters, where for some of our models that are doing very well, we are doubling our capacity," Chitale said.

With the company doing "60,000-odd scooter volume run rate" monthly at present, when asked if doubling it could mean closer to 1 lakh, he said,"That's our ambition."

Elaborating on the scooter capacity expansion, Chitale said in the ICE (internal combustion engine) scooters, Hero MotoCorp has increased 'Destini' model capacity by 50 per cent already.

"We are in the process of doubling our Xoom capacity," he added.

On EV, he said,"We are close to completing an expansion, which will effectively get us 50 per cent more capacity than the last quarter and then additional few quarters down the road, we are in process of further doubling capacity." PTI

India and other oil importing countries to bilaterally negotiate transit corridors with Iran: Moody's Ratings

NEW DELHI: India and other oil importing nations are likely to negotiate bilaterally to secure energy supplies, potentially through coordinated transit corridors, but a return to pre-war traffic volumes is unlikely in 2026, Moody's Ratings has said.

In a global report on geopolitical risks, Moody's said there is little prospect of a swift and durable settlement between the US and Iran and with it the full reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Moody's said the transit flows will gradually improve, but through bilateral channels rather than a general reopening. This would allow some incremental improvement in energy transit flows from near-zero now, but the process will be slow, opaque and subject to interruption.

"We expect oil importers — particularly China, India, Japan and Korea — to negotiate passage bilaterally with Iran, potentially through coordinated transit corridors such as those reportedly emerging near Larak Island and through Omani territorial waters... A return to pre-conflict traffic volumes in 2026 is unlikely," it said.

Moody's said even if safe passage in the Strait were to resume in the next six months, the oil market would remain

supply-constrained, with persistently higher and more volatile energy prices and broader knock-on effects through costs, demand and financing conditions for exposed borrowers.

"We now expect Brent crude in the $90-110/bbl range for much of this year, with significant volatility, including occasional fluctuations outside this range in response to new developments," Moody's said in its May 12 report.

At sustained Brent prices of $90-110/bbl, Moody's estimates real GDP growth reductions of 0.2-0.8 percentage point for several major economies.

"India is among the most exposed, given around 46 per cent of its crude oil imports come from the Middle East, its sensitivity to currency depreciation and pressure on its current account and fiscal management," Moody's said.

Moody's in its May Global Macro outlook slashed India's GDP growth estimate for 2026 calendar year by 0.8 percentage points to 6 per cent.

The Middle East conflict, which started with the US and Israel joint air strikes on Iran has entered its third month. The attack triggered the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, a key chokepoint through which roughly one-fifth of the world's seaborne crude oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) passed in peacetime.

Maritime traffic through the Strait has fallen by more than 90 per cent from pre-conflict levels, with shipping activity curbed by risk aversion, high insurance costs and the presence of sea mines. Brent crude has fluctuated widely between $90 and $120/bbl. PTI

Vessel carrying 20,000 MT of LPG reaches Gujarat crossing Strait of Hormuz

KANDLA (Gujarat): A vessel carrying 20,000 metric tonnes of LPG arrived at Deendayal Port Authority in Kandla in Gujarat after crossing the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia crisis, officials said on Sunday.

The Marshall Islands-flagged MV SYMI started its journey from Qatar and docked at the port in Kandla around 11.30 pm on Saturday after crossing the Strait of Hormuz on May 13, they added.

Since early March, 13 India-flagged vessels, comprising 12 LPG tankers and one crude oil tanker, have crossed the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow waterway close to the coast of Oman through which roughly one-fifth of the world's energy supplies pass.

It has been severely disrupted by the conflict in West Asia that started on February 28, with the US and Israel launching joint attacks on Iran, triggering retaliatory strikes. It has resulted in one of the worst energy crisis the world has seen in recent decades. PTI

Hybrid mutual funds attract ₹1.55 lakh crore in FY26 on diversified investment appeal

According to data from AMFI, number of hybrid fund folios rose to 1.9 crore in March 2026 from 1.56 crore a year earlier, adding 34 lakh investor accounts

NEW DELHI: Hybrid mutual fund schemes attracted inflows of Rs 1.55 lakh crore in 2025-26, a 29 per cent increase over the preceding fiscal year, as investors increasingly turned to diversified investment strategies amid volatile market conditions.

The category witnessed strong traction despite heightened geopolitical tensions, including the conflict in West Asia, as investors sought balanced investment solutions that could cushion market volatility.

"Hybrid funds saw strong traction in FY26 as investors looked for balanced investment solutions during volatile times. Multi asset allocation funds, in particular, gained popularity due to their ability to deliver relatively stable performance across market cycles," Radhika Gupta, MD and CEO of Edelweiss Mutual Fund, said.

According to data from the Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI), the number of hybrid fund folios rose to 1.9 crore in March 2026 from 1.56 crore a year earlier, adding 34 lakh investor accounts.

Assets under management (AUM) of hybrid schemes increased to Rs 10.35 lakh crore in March 2026 from Rs 8.83 lakh crore in March 2025, registering a growth of 17 per cent.

"The growth in AUM reflects rising investor preference for diversified portfolios and asset allocation-led investing. Hybrid funds have increasingly become a core allocation for investors seeking participation in equities with relatively moderated risk," Gupta said.

Equity markets remained volatile during FY26 due to global uncertainties, including tariff concerns under US President Donald Trump, the ongoing Russia-Ukraine conflict and rising geopolitical tensions in West Asia. During the same period, gold outperformed

CLOSER LOOK

» AUM of hybrid schemes rose to Rs 10.35 lakh crore in March 2026 from Rs 8.83 lakh crore in March 2025

» 'Between April 2025 and April 2026, the AUM of the broader hybrid category grew about 21 per cent'

» During FY26, 17 hybrid fund new fund offers were launched compared with 12 in the previous fiscal year

equities in the short-term, benefiting hybrid categories that maintained exposure to the precious metal.

"As a result, many hybrid funds were able to deliver relatively stable and higher near-term risk-adjusted performance compared to pure equity funds, which created recent bias in investors across this category," Feroze Azeez, Joint CEO of Anand Rathi Wealth Ltd, said.

Additionally, investors increasingly preferred diversified and asset-allocation-based strategies to navigate uncertain market conditions, which further supported strong inflows into hybrid mutual funds during FY26, he added.

Rajesh Singla, CEO and Fund Manager at Alpha AMC, said hybrid funds gained traction as they offered downside protection through debt investments.

"The jump from Rs 1.2 lakh crore in FY25 to Rs 1.55 lakh crore in FY26 was not an accident, it was investors doing exactly what they should do when the world gets complicated," he said.

"When geopolitical uncertainty drives oil above $100 and equity markets start swinging 2-3 per cent in a single session, pure equity funds feel uncomfortable. Hybrid funds offer something that pure equity cannot — a built-in cushion," Singla added.

He noted that multi-asset allocation funds were a key driver of growth, while arbitrage funds also attracted significant flows due to their low-risk and tax-efficient nature.

"Between April 2025 and April 2026, the AUM of the broader hybrid category grew about 21 per cent, while multi-asset funds within the category witnessed growth of over 65 per cent," Varun Gupta, CEO of Groww Mutual Fund, said.

"This trend suggests that investors are increasingly looking at diversification within the market, rather than avoiding the market altogether, as a way to navigate uncertain periods," he added.

During FY26, 17 hybrid fund new fund offers (NFOs) were launched compared with 12 in the previous fiscal year.

However, cumulative inflows through these NFOs moderated to around Rs 4,106 crore from nearly Rs 4,792 crore in FY25. PTI

'FTAs, lower import duties & better biz environment to boost FDI flows'

During 2021-22, India attracted net FDI of $38.6 billion, which came down to $28 billion in FY23 and further fell to $10.2 billion in FY24

NEW DELHI: Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), reduction in import tariffs and improvement in business environment would encourage higher net foreign capital inflows into India, which have moderated in recent years, ADB Chief Economist Albert Park has said.

During 2021-22, India attracted net Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) of $38.6 billion, which came down to $28 billion in FY23 and further fell to $10.2 billion in FY24.

Net FDI — inflow minus outflow — came down significantly to single digit to $1 billion in FY25 but improved to $3 billion during the April-December period of FY26.

The government should continue reducing import tariffs to ensure foreign investments remain competitive, he said.

It also needs to strengthen the overall manufacturing ecosystem by developing industrial zones with robust infrastructure and integrated facilities, making them easier for foreign firms to address their business needs efficiently in one place, he said, adding that free trade agreements should help increase foreign direct investment flow in India.

Net FDI — inflow minus outflow — came down significantly to single digit to $1 billion in FY25 but improved to $3 billion during the April-December period of FY26

"Asian Development Bank has also been pushing the idea of better governance of cities. This involves a form of integrated planning that encompasses the logistical, regulatory, and human capital needs of the businesses. Smart urbanism that addresses the concerns of the business community," he said.

Stressing that uncertainty always leads to a flight of capital to safety, Park said the Asian market is witnessing this phenomenon triggered by uncertainty.

Asia is a little bit more vulnerable to the Middle East shocks than other parts of the world, he added.

Highlights

- » The govt should continue reducing import tariffs to ensure foreign investments remain competitive, ADB Chief Economist Albert Park said
- » Appreciating various reforms, including labour & GST, he said India should continue the momentum
- » 'With a higher oil price expectation, we actually have it as $96/barrel as avg for 2026 as per the new reference scenario'

Appreciating various reforms, including labour and GST undertaken by India, Park said India should continue the momentum.

On the outlook on crude oil prices, Park said they are likely to stay higher for longer due to the disruption caused by the longer-than-expected Middle East crisis.

"With a higher oil price expectation, we actually have it as $96 per barrel as average for 2026 as per the new reference scenario. It should stay elevated at $80 per barrel in 2027. So, our idea is that oil prices are likely to stay higher for longer," he said.

Future prices are showing higher prices farther out into next year than they did before, he said.

However, he said, "We have also seen always a kind of a premium of the spot market prices and the nearby futures market because there is such a shortage currently."

On the impact of the ongoing Middle East crisis on India, Park said it is going to shave off 0.6 per cent from the country's GDP growth, bringing it to 6.3 per cent, and also stoke inflation significantly in the current financial year.

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) in April projected India's GDP growth to remain "robust" at 6.9 per cent in the current fiscal year, and rise to 7.3 per cent in FY28, driven by strong domestic demand.

With regard to inflation, ADB had projected 4.5 per cent for the current fiscal year. PTI

N America, NE Asia, Latin America drive 35% of India exports in FY26

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: North America, North-East Asia, and Latin America together accounted for over 35 per cent of India's merchandise exports, which stood at $441.78 billion in 2025-26, reflecting a gradual shift towards a more diversified and resilient global trade structure, according to Commerce Ministry data.

Exports to East Africa increased 13.7 per cent to $12.6 billion, accounting for 2.9 per cent of India's exports, while North Africa rose 14.8 per cent to $8 billion with a 1.8 per cent share.

"India's exports in 2025-26 reflected increasing geographic diversification, with strong growth across Asia, Africa, and Latin America even amid global trade disruptions," an official said.

According to the data, while North America continued to dominate India's export basket with exports of $97.7 billion accounting for 22.1 per cent of total exports, growth remained relatively moderate at 1.3 per cent year-on-year, that indicates to a mature but resilient demand base.

The strongest momentum came from North-East Asia, where exports surged 21.6 per cent to $41.6 billion, raising the region's share to 9.4 per cent of India's total exports.

In this region, there is a rising demand for Indian electronics, engineering goods, chemicals, and industrial products.

Exports to East Africa jumped 13.7 per cent to $12.6 billion, accounting for 2.9 per cent of India's exports, while North Africa rose 14.8 per cent to $8 billion with a 1.8 per cent share

The countries in this region include China, Japan, South Korea, North Korea, Mongolia, and Taiwan. These countries have advance manufacturing industries.

Latin America maintained healthy expansion as exports rose 7.8 per cent to $16.4 billion, contributing 3.7 per cent to India's total exports.

Meanwhile, exports to West Africa and Other West Asia remained relatively stable around 3 per cent and 2 per cent shares, respectively.

Smaller regions such as Central Africa and Central Asian Republic countries also posted steady double-digit growth, albeit from a lower base.

India's export diversification in FY2025-26 was marked by a significant widening of its product-market footprint, with Indian exporters penetrating 1,821 new principal commodities products.

"The trend highlights a gradual shift from traditional commodity-led expansion toward broader participation across high-value manufacturing, engineering, agri-processing, and technology-intensive sectors," the official said.

The strongest value contribution came from advanced engineering and industrial sectors. Ship, boat and floating structures emerged as the single largest contributor, generating $57 million across 19 new markets, reflecting India's growing competitiveness in specialised maritime manufacturing.

Similarly, nuclear reactors, industrial boilers and parts recorded a $14.3 million across 13 new markets, while telecom instruments expanded into 20 new markets with exports of $5.8 million, indicating increasing integration into global industrial and technology supply chains.

Further, several emerging sectors also gained traction in new markets, including aircraft and spacecraft parts, railway transport equipment, graphite and explosives, and consumer electronics, pointing toward a gradual broadening of India's advanced manufacturing export base.

'Silver import Curbs to keep bullion mkts volatile this week'

NEW DELHI: Gold and silver markets brace for a volatile week ahead amid the government's latest curbs on silver imports, movement in crude oil prices and global uncertainty surrounding the US-Iran conflict, analysts said.

On the economic front, investors will closely track Chinese economic data, US housing numbers, PMI data, weekly jobless claims and minutes of the FOMC meeting, they added.

On the MCX, gold futures rose Rs 6,017, or 3.94 per cent, during the past week to settle at Rs 1.58 lakh per 10 grams. Silver futures also climbed Rs 9,964, or 3.8 per cent, to close at Rs 2.71 lakh per kg.

In contrast, international bullion prices remained under pressure last week.

Comex gold futures declined by $168.8, or 3.6 per cent during the last week, to close at $4,561.9 per ounce.

Silver futures also slipped by $3.32, or 4.11 per cent during the past week to settle at $77.54 per ounce.

Analysts said rupee movement will also remain a key factor influencing domestic bullion prices, while fluctuations in crude oil and global macroeconomic developments could further shape market sentiment. Market participants will also watch the transition at the US Federal Reserve, with Kevin Warsh set to officially take over from Jerome Powell on Monday after Powell's eight-year term ends, they added. PTI

FPIs pull out ₹27,048 cr so far in May

NEW DELHI: Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) continued to pare their exposure to Indian equities, withdrawing Rs 27,048 crore so far this month, indicating cautiousness among global investors amid an evolving global macroeconomic and geopolitical environment.

With this, total outflows by FPIs from the equity market have reached Rs 2.2 lakh crore in 2026, higher than the Rs 1.66 lakh crore pulled out during the entire 2025, according to data with the NSDL.

FPIs were net sellers in all months of 2026, except February. They withdrew Rs 35,962 crore in January before turning net buyers in February, when they invested Rs 22,615 crore, the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

However, the trend reversed in March, when foreign investors pulled out a record Rs 1.17 lakh crore. The selling continued in April with net outflows of Rs 60,847 crore and withdrawals into May with withdrawals of over Rs 27,000 crore so far.

With this, total outflows by FPIs from equity market have reached Rs 2.2 lakh cr in 2026

Himanshu Srivastava, Principal - Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India, said the latest outflow trend reflected persistent uncertainty surrounding global growth, elevated geopolitical tensions across key regions and volatility in crude oil prices, which continued to weigh on risk appetite towards emerging markets, including India.

He added that a stronger US dollar and elevated US bond yields remained key drivers behind the selling activity, as higher returns in developed markets improved the relative attractiveness of safer assets and prompted investors to adopt a more defensive stance.

Srivastava further said concerns over the trajectory of global inflation and uncertainty regarding the pace and timing of future interest rate cuts by major central banks continued to influence capital allocation decisions globally.

Geojit Investments Chief Investment Strategist V K Vijayakumar said sustained FPI selling, coupled with a widening current account deficit, has exerted pressure on the rupee.

"At the beginning of the year, the rupee was at 90 to the US dollar. On May 15, it breached the 96-mark to touch 96.14," he said. Vijayakumar said the rupee could weaken further if FPI outflows persist and crude oil prices remain elevated. He also noted that the continuing flow of capital into artificial intelligence-focused companies globally has led to some diversion of funds away from markets such as India, which are seen as lagging in the AI space. PTI

Mcap of 9 of top 10 valued companies erodes by ₹3.12 lakh crore, Reliance biggest laggard

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of nine of the top 10 valued firms eroded by Rs 3.12 lakh crore last week, with Reliance Industries taking the biggest hit. Last week, the 30-share BSE Sensex fell 2,090.2 points, or 2.7 per cent, while the 50-share NSE Nifty declined 532.65 points, or 2.2 per cent.

From the top-10 pack, Bharti Airtel emerged as the only winner.

The market valuation of Reliance Industries tumbled Rs 1,34,445.77 crore to Rs 18,08,420.81 crore. SBI's valuation eroded by Rs 52,245.30 crore to Rs 8,88,862.32 crore.

The valuation of TCS tanked Rs 47,415.04 crore to Rs 8,19,062.65 crore and that of Bajaj Finance dived Rs 27,892.28 crore to Rs 5,66,717.74 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of HDFC Bank dropped by Rs 20,630.01 crore to Rs 11,82,069.25 crore.

ICICI Bank's market capitalisation diminished by Rs 14,290 crore to Rs 8,92,385.39 crore.

Market Cap

Top 10 (BSE)

₹ crore	As on May 15, 2026	Gain/Loss over May 9
RIL	18,08,420.81	▽ -1,34,445.77
HDFC Bank	11,82,069.25	▽ -20,630.01
Bharti Airtel	11,60,525.16	△ 42,470.13
ICICI Bank	8,92,385.39	▽ -14,290.00
SBI	8,88,862.32	▽ -52,245.30
TCS	8,19,062.65	▽ -47,415.04
Bajaj Finance	5,66,717.74	▽ -27,892.28
Larsen & Toubro	5,37,542.34	▽ -9,078.87
Hind Unilever	5,33,592.18	▽ -3,970.80
LIC	5,05,367.32	▽ -2,182.12

Source: BSE

KBK Infographics

Last week, BSE Sensex fell 2,090.2 points, or 2.7%, while NSE Nifty tanked 532.65 points, or 2.2%

L&Ts mcap edged lower by Rs 9,078.87 crore to Rs 5,37,542.34 crore, and that of Hindustan Unilever fell by Rs 3,970.80 crore to Rs 5,33,592.18 crore. The mcap of LIC dipped by Rs 2,182.12 crore to Rs 5,05,367.32 crore.

However, the market valuation of Bharti Airtel jumped Rs 42,470.13 crore to Rs 11,60,525.16 crore. Reliance Industries remained the most valued firm followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, SBI, TCS, Bajaj Finance, L&T, Hindustan Unilever & LIC. PTI

US-Iran conflict, crude oil prices key market drivers for Dalal Street this week, say analysts

NEW DELHI: The US-Iran conflict, FII flows and crude oil prices will be the major drivers for Dalal Street this week, with inflation adding to investor anxiety, say analysts.

Besides, the rupee's movement, which crashed below the 96 mark against the US dollar last week, would also influence trading sentiment. The rupee crashed below the 96/USD mark on Friday amid elevated crude oil prices and inflation concerns.

"Markets are expected to remain highly volatile and intensely headline-driven, with investor sentiment continuing to hinge on developments surrounding the ongoing US–Iran conflict, diplomatic negotiations and movements in global energy markets," Ponmudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said. Markets are likely to remain extremely sensitive to any developments linked to the Strait of Hormuz, given its critical importance to global energy supply chains, he said.

"Any credible diplomatic progress or easing in tensions could trigger short-covering rallies across equities, support emerging market sentiment and help moderate crude oil prices. Conversely, any renewed escalation, disruption to shipping routes or deterioration in negotiations could rapidly revive risk-off positioning, intensify volatility and place renewed pressure on equities, currencies and commodities globally," Ponmudi added. In addition to geopolitical developments, investors will closely monitor rupee movement, institutional flow trends and global equity performance for directional cues, Ponmudi said.

IOC, BPCL, GAIL and NTPC would announce their quarterly earnings this week

Santosh Meena, Head of Research at Swastika Investmart Ltd, said, going into the week ahead, the key focus will continue to remain on geopolitical developments and the trajectory of crude oil prices.

Additionally, macroeconomic data releases from China, the US, and India, along with the minutes of the US FOMC (Federal Open Market Committee) meeting, will be closely tracked by investors, he said, adding that the tail end of the earnings season may also continue to drive stock-specific action across sectors.

IOC, BPCL, GAIL and NTPC would announce their quarterly earnings this week. PTI

Loans likely to cross ₹1 lakh crore milestone in FY27, says IRFC CMD

NEW DELHI: State-owned Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) has set a target of crossing a milestone of Rs 1 lakh crore loan sanction during the current financial year.

To fund its business growth, IRFC is looking to raise Rs 70,000 crore, including from overseas in FY27.

"We are aiming for a loan sanction of Rs 1 lakh crore and disbursement of about Rs 40,000 crore during the ongoing financial year, as the pipeline of high-quality infrastructure projects looks strong," IRFC Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey said.

A steady pipeline and emerging opportunities in sectors such as metro and ports are expected to further accelerate growth in the coming financial year, following its whole-of-government approach, he said.

During FY26, IRFC sanctioned projects worth Rs 72,949 crore and disbursed approximately Rs 35,067 crore, exceeding its annual guidance.

The company, which last year got Navratna status, witnessed its net worth raising to all-time high at Rs 56,748 crore and AUM crossing a record high at Rs 4.85 lakh crore.

The diversification-led expansion resulted in improved spreads and a consistent rise in net interest margin (NIM), while IRFC maintained its zero NPA status.

"Our diversification strategy is now translating into stronger spreads, improved margins and enhanced shareholder value, he said, adding that NIM should further improve to 1.65 per cent in FY27 as against 1.5 per cent recorded in FY26. He further said IRFC made a structural shift in business model, from a traditional railway financier to a diversified infrastructure financing institution keeping railways at its Centre.

With Indian Railways not availing fresh disbursements since 2023-24, the company has expanded into sectors with strong forward and backward linkages to railways, including power generation, renewable energy, transmission, fertilisers and railway-linked infrastructure. PTI

NCLAT upholds separate insolvency process for Videocon Industries, Videocon Oil Ventures

'One single entity wouldn't have expertise to revive these varied businesses'

NEW DELHI: The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has upheld separate insolvency proceedings for Videocon Industries Ltd (VIL) and Videocon Oil Ventures Ltd (VOVL), setting aside an earlier NCLT order that had directed consolidation of the two cases.

In a final order dated May 14, 2026, the appellate tribunal said creditors had consciously decided to run separate Corporate Insolvency Resolution Processes (CIRPs) for the two companies due to the distinct nature of their businesses and the need for specialised buyers.

VIL operates in the consumer electronics segment, while VOVL is engaged in oil and gas businesses. "One single entity would not have the expertise to revive these varied businesses," the NCLAT bench of Justice Yogesh Khanna and Ajai Das Mehrotra observed.

The tribunal noted that Bharat Petroleum subsidiary BPRL had already acquired VOVL by exercising its Right of First Refusal (ROFR), an arrangement approved by the NCLT in June 2024, while the CIRP of VIL remains pending.

According to NCLAT, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code aims to keep corporate debtors as going concerns while resolving creditor dues.

It held that the Committee of Creditors (CoC) had exercised its commercial wisdom in opting for separate CIRPs to attract buyers with sector-specific expertise, and such decisions should not be interfered with by tribunals.

The appellate tribunal also rejected submissions by Videocon founder Venugopal Dhoot, who had sought inclusion of foreign oil and gas assets in VIL's insolvency process.

NCLAT noted that Dhoot himself had earlier sought removal of VIL as a co-obligor to ring-fence foreign oil and gas assets from the financial troubles of the domestic business.

The tribunal described his stand as "flip-flops" marked by contradictions. The dispute dates back to 2018 when insolvency proceedings were initiated against VIL on an SBI plea, followed by VOVL's insolvency in 2019. AGENCIES

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE

REC Ltd has committed financial assistance of Rs 1.40 crore under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative for implementation of the 'Green Innovator Immersive Learning Lab' project in 10 Govt Schools of Karnal District, Haryana. The project will be executed by I-Hub Foundation for Cobotics. A Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) in this regard was signed on May 14 2026 at REC Corporate Office, Gurugram, between Arun Kumar Tyagi, Executive Director (CSR), REC Ltd & Ashutosh Dutt Sharma, CEO, IHFC (IIT Delhi).

Central Bank of India Organised Nationwide Mega MSME Outreach Programme in Faridabad on May 16, 2026. The programme was graced by the presence of Tarsem Singh Zira, Zonal Head, Delhi and Dr. Himanshu Gupta, GM, MSME. A major highlight of the event was the on-the-spot sanctioning of loans worth Rs 75 crore, reaffirming the Bank's strong commitment to supporting entrepreneurship and industrial development. The event concluded with a vote of thanks by Rahul Saxena, Regional Head, Gurugram.

PUNJAB DEFEATED BY 23 RUNS

RCB secure playoffs berth as PBKS slump to 6th straight defeat

DHARAMSALA: Royal Challengers Bengaluru held their nerve and survived a late onslaught to edge out Punjab Kings by 23 runs to become the first team to secure an IPL playoffs berth with an all-round performance here on Sunday.

Venkatesh Iyer blasted a spectacular 40-ball 73 not out and powered RCB to 222 for four. Virat Kohli (58 off 37 balls), Devdutt Padikkal (45 off 25 balls) and Tim David (28 off 12) were the other significant contributors for RCB after they were asked to bat first.

In reply, PBKS were stopped at 199 for eight after Shashank Singh's valiant 56 off 27 balls, the home team suffering its sixth consecutive defeat after a great start to the season.

In a daunting chase of 223, Punjab Kings endured a nervy start as RCB's pace attack kept the batters under pressure in the first 10 overs.

PBKS were jolted early when veteran seamer Bhuvneshwar Kumar removed Priyansh Arya in the opening over, forcing the hosts on to the back foot immediately.

With the required rate hovering around 11-an-over from the outset, Punjab's batters were compelled to attack but RCB's disciplined bowling and sharp fielding denied the home side the momentum they were looking for. Cooper Connolly and Prabhsimran Singh looked to counterattack with a few boundaries, but the visitors continued to chip away with timely breakthroughs.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru's Virat Kohli celebrates with teammates after winning the IPL match against Punjab Kings,in Dharamshala on Sunday PTI

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PBKS were stopped at 199 for eight after Shashank Singh's valiant 56 off 27 balls, the home team suffering its sixth consecutive defeat after a great start to the season

Prabhsimran threw his bat at a Bhuvneshwar delivery way outside off and the edge flew to Devdutt in the slips. Skipper Shreyas Iyer too bit the dust inside the Power Play.

After reaching 35 off 22 balls, Suryansh Shedge hit an innocuous Suyash Sharma delivery to long-off, where Kohli completed a neat, flat catch. However, Shashank kept up the fight with his bold hits, including three sixes in one over against Suyash, even as Jacob Bethell dropped Marcus Stoinis on 22, who too found the boundaries at will to keep PKBS in the hunt.

But Josh Hazlewood returned to dismiss Stoinis (37 off 25) with a full toss which the batter failed to put away.

Shashank continued to battle for PBKS as Bhuvneshwar, who gave away just eight runs in his first spell, leaked 30 runs in his last two overs.

However, Shashank's innings came to an end in the final over in which PBKS needed 33 runs. AGENCIES

Delhi Capitals beat Rajasthan Royals by 5 wickets in IPL

NEW DELHI: Abhishek Porel and KL Rahul hit fluent half-centuries as Delhi Capitals overhauled a competitive Rajasthan Royals total to register a five-wicket victory in their Indian Premier League clash here on Sunday.

Porel, playing only his third IPL match of the season, looked in fine touch during his 31-ball 51, while KL Rahul bounced back from a couple of underwhelming outings with a composed 56 off 42 deliveries as Delhi Capitals completed the chase of 194 in 19.2 overs.

The opening pair stitched together a match-winning 105-run partnership that laid the foundation for DC's chase, before Axar Patel scored an unbeaten 34 off 18 deliveries to complete the chase.

Earlier, Mitchell Starc starred with the ball for DC, producing a devastating spell of fast bowling to restrict Rajasthan Royals to 193 for 8.

Starc ripped through the RR middle order in a dramatic 15th over, dismissing a well-set Riyan Parag (51), Donovan Ferreira (0) and Ravi Singh (4). The left-arm pacer struck off the second, third and fifth deliveries of the over, narrowly missing out on a hat-trick.

Despite the collapse, Rajasthan Royals still managed a competitive total thanks to impressive half-centuries from

Delhi Capitals' captain Axar Patel plays a shot during an Indian Premier League match, in New Delhi on Sunday PTI

skipper Parag and Dhruv Jurel, who made 53 off 40 balls, while young opener Vaibhav Sooryavanshi contributed a valuable 46 at the top of the order.

Brief Scores:

Rajasthan Royals: 193 for 8 in 20 overs (Vaibhav Sooryavanshi 46, Dhruv Jurel 53, Riyan Parag 51; Lungi Ngidi 2/24, Madhav Tiwari 2/27, Mitchell Starc 4/40). AGENCIES

Rishabh Pant could be relieved from Test vice-captaincy to help him focus on batting

NEW DELHI: The Indian Test team won't have too many surprises but there could be serious conversations about Rishabh Pant's future as red-ball format vice-captain when the national selectors meet in Guwahati on Tuesday to select Test and ODI squads for the series against Afghanistan.

It is understood that there is a growing feeling that the leadership role isn't sitting well with the 28-year-old flamboyant keeper-batter as two seasons with Lucknow Super Giants offers a testimony.

It's also not to be forgotten that Pant wasn't tactically very astute when handed captaincy in the absence of Shubman Gill during a Test match against South Africa in Guwahati last November.

"Indian cricket simply cannot afford to lose a batting match-winner like Rishabh. He has won and set-up Test matches with his aggressive batting. There is a growing feeling among men who matter that whenever he has been entrusted with additional responsibility, he doesn't seem to make good decisions while batting," a BCCI source told PTI on conditions of anonymity.

Rishabh Pant during a training session PTI

"Giving him an opportunity to play freely could be foremost on the minds of the selection committee." Pant's current form could also give sleepless nights to the selection committee as there remains a question mark about his place as second wicketkeeper in the ODI set-up behind KL Rahul.

With Dhruv Jurel, Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan also in the ranks, Pant could feel the heat as far as 50-over set-up is concerned.

If the BCCI medical team is fine with Jasprit Bumrah's workload, then the senior pacer will play the one-off Test but there is absolutely no chance of him playing the three-match ODI series looking at his workload during the ongoing IPL.

> With Dhruv Jurel, Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan also in the ranks, Pant could feel the heat as far as 50-over set-up is concerned

"If the medical team appoves Bumrah's workload and is under permissible limits, he might play the Test match against Afghanistan.

"But there is no chance of him playing the ODI series. If there is slightest issue with his workload, he will be rested for the full series," said the BCCI source privy to developments.

Prince Yadav, the find among Indian pacers during this IPL season, hasn't been picked for the tri-nation List A series in Sri Lanka because he is a serious contender to be picked for the ODI series against Afghanistan. AGENCIES

Satwik-Chirag suffer blowout in Thailand finals

BANGKOK: Star Indian pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty saved four championship points before going down fighting against Indonesia's Leo Rolly Carnando and Daniel Marthin in a gripping men's doubles final to finish runners-up at the Thailand Open Super 500 tournament here on Sunday.

World No. 4 Satwik and Chirag, champions here in 2019 and 2024, looked off-colour in the opening game but showed great mental fortitude under pressure in the second to almost take the match to the decider before losing 12-21 23-25 in a 53-minute summit clash.

It was another creditable finish for Satwik and Chirag, who have established themselves as India's most consistent doubles pair in recent years.

For the Indian duo, who had missed some tournaments due to Satwik's shoulder injury, it was a third final appearance at the USD 475,000 event and their first of the season.

They had also finished runners-up at the China Masters and Hong Kong Open last year.

Despite the defeat, Satwik was pleased with the overall progress after the duo's return from injury setbacks. AGENCIES

"Except for today, I am happy with the way we played this week. It is more mental than physical now," he said.

"We need to believe more instead of playing 50-50 badminton. Things have started working for us and hopefully soon we will be on the winning side instead of the losing side."

Satwik admitted the Indian pair took time to adjust to the faster shuttles and Indonesia's attacking game style after being outplayed in the opening game. AGENCIES

Mohun Bagan hold East Bengal 1-1 in dramatic ISL Kolkata derbya

The result kept both the teams level on 23 points

KOLKATA: Mohun Bagan Super Giant struck late through Jason Cummings to snatch a dramatic 1-1 draw against arch-rivals East Bengal in a tense and emotionally-charged Indian Super League Kolkata derby here on Sunday.

In a cagey contest packed with missed chances, fierce tackles and late drama, East Bengal looked set for their first-ever ISL derby win after substitute Edmund Lalrindika broke the deadlock in the 85th minute. But Mohun Bagan responded almost immediately as substitute Cummings headed home from a corner in the 90th minute to deny East Bengal a famous victory.

The result kept both teams level on 23 points, though East Bengal retained a five-goal advantage over Mohun Bagan heading into the final round on May 21. While Mohun Bagan will face 11th-placed SC Delhi at the Salt Lake Stadium, East Bengal will take on ninth-placed Inter Kashi at Kishore Bharati, with both matches to be played simultaneously.

Played in front of a packed 62,201 crowd at the Salt Lake Stadium, the derby also carried emotional significance following the death of former Mohun Bagan president Swapan Sadhan "Tutu" Bose on Thursday at the age of 79. A minute's silence was observed before kick-off, while giant posters of Bose adorned the stands in tribute to the man who guided the club for nearly three decades.

Mohun Bagan Super Giant's Jason Cummings, right, Dimitri Petratos, left, and others celebrate a goal during an ISL match in Kolkata on Sunday PTI

> EAST BENGAL RESPONDED ALMOST IMMEDIATELY AS BIPIN SINGH BROKE THROUGH ON GOAL

Mohun Bagan dominated possession for large periods in the first half, but East Bengal looked dangerous on the counter in an open and frantic contest. The home side threatened as early as the fourth minute when Liston Colaco slipped Subhasish Bose into the East Bengal box before Sahal Abdul Samad failed to control the cutback. East Bengal responded almost immediately as Bipin Singh broke through on goal, only for Abhishek Singh to produce a crucial tackle.

Liston looked lively down the left flank throughout and repeatedly troubled Mohammed Rakip, while Mohun Bagan continued to press through Sahal Abdul Samad and Jamie Maclaren.

However, East Bengal squandered two golden opportunities midway through the first half. First, Danish forward Anton Sojberg bulldozed his way past Tom Aldred before smashing a fierce left-footed shot against the far post in the 15th minute. AGENCIES

Sinner becomes 1st Italian man to win Italian Open in 50 years

ROME: Italian tennis fans had waited for this moment for a half century. For Jannik Sinner, though, it wasn't just about becoming the first Italian man to win the Italian Open since Adriano Panatta 50 years ago.

The top-ranked Sinner's 6-4, 6-4 victory over Casper Ruud in Sunday's final on the red clay of the Foro Italico also made him only the second man after Novak Djokovic to win all nine Masters 1000 events — the biggest tournaments outside the Grand Slams.

Djokovic completed the career set in 2018 in Cincinnati at age 31 — and then went on to win each event at least twice. Sinner is 24, and with his only real rival, Carlos Alcaraz, currently sidelined due to a right wrist injury, seemingly nobody can beat him. Sinner extended his winning streak to 29 matches. He hasn't lost since getting beat by Jakub Mensik in the Qatar Open quarterfinals on Feb. 19. And he's now 17-0 on clay this year entering the French Open, which starts next Sunday.

Incredible," Sinner said. "It's been a long time since an Italian won – 50 years. I'm happy one of us was able to take advantage of this great period for Italian tennis." AGENCIES

Tara Sutaria calls *Toxic* 'FEARLESS, FABULOUS'

'Reasons behind Toxic's delay are valid,' says the actress

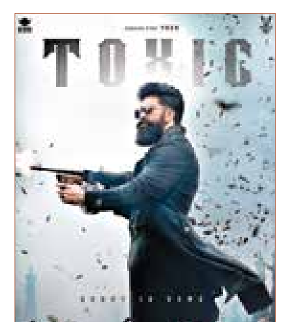
'Toxic', starring Yash, was initially scheduled to release alongside 'Dhurandhar 2' on March 19. However, on Holi, the makers announced that the film had been postponed to June 4. Later, Yash announced another delay due to the makers 'currently aligning global distribution and partnerships'.

One of the film's co-stars, Tara Sutaria, opened up about the same. The makers are yet to announce Toxic's new release date.

Speaking to 'The Hollywood Reporter India' at the Cannes Film Festival, Tara said, "Doing 'Toxic' has been so satisfying and fulfilling. I want to be on sets that make me feel good - sets that are led with integrity, purpose and intention - and we have all of those things with Geethu Mohandas and Yash. It has been one of the joys of my life to be directed by Geethu Mohandas and by a woman. There is a world of difference on set."

Talking about her role in the film, Tara added, "I can tell you that my character is fascinating. In fact, all the women in this film are fascinating. It is an ensemble-cast film where every character has immense power and courage. The film is fearless and fabulous."

She further revealed that the film would present audiences with a fresh visual style. "We are talking about a period where visually and stylistically all of us have very exciting personal styles, something I don't think Indian cinema has explored in a long time. Globally, it's going to be something people won't expect," she shared.



The makers are yet to announce the film's new release date

Praising her co-stars, Tara said, "It has also been wonderful to watch so many women come together alongside Yash, who is incredible both as a human being and a co-star. To see women from different ages and stages of life and career come together and celebrate every scene has been truly special. We are not all together in every scene, so whenever it happens, it feels rare and magical."

Addressing the repeated delays in the film's release, Tara said she remains patient and understands the bigger picture behind such decisions. AGENCIES

Respect his space: Adnan Sami

The singer-composer talked about Arijit Singh's decision to retire from playback singing

Sami added that Singh is under no obligation to publicly explain the reasons behind his decision

MUMBAI: Singer-composer Adnan Sami, who weighed in on Arijit Singh stepping away from playback singing, said his decision should be 'respected' and not speculated upon. Earlier this year, Singh shocked both the film and music industry, along with his fans, when he announced his retirement from playback singing through a social media post.

"He's made a conscious decision to retire from playback singing. Whatever his decision is, one should allow him the space to respect that decision. He's not come up with that decision out of any kind of impulse; it must be a very well-thought-out decision," Sami told PTI.

Speaking on the sidelines of the launch of his new single, 'Lipstick Laga Ke, Nazar Utar Le', under 'Zee Music Company', Sami added that Singh is under no obligation to publicly explain the reasons behind his decision. "It must be for a very good reason, which he knows. It isn't necessary for him to disclose that or maybe in due course, the world will find out why. It's his life and when he feels that he is ready to share the reason, he'll say it if at all he feels like it, but that space should be given to him," he explained.

Sami's remarks come at a time when Singh's decision to step away from playback singing at the height of his career has triggered widespread discussion about mental health, emotional exhaustion and the pressures associated with the music industry.

The 54-year-old singer-composer described it as 'unfair' to generalise or speculate about the reasons behind Singh's decision. "Taking a break from work is subjective and you can't generalise it for one particular reason. Everybody can have various reasons behind it," he said.

Addressing the query around industry pressures, Sami said that while different music labels and companies operate with their own frameworks, artistes ultimately are free to choose what works best for them. "They are just hoping that the people who are going to collaborate with them will follow that particular policy. It will suit some people, it will not suit others and some companies are very rigid about what direction they want their releases to take, subject-wise. Some are very open to giving more freedom, while others are not," Sami added. PTI

John Travolta surprised with Palme d'Or at CANNES FILM FESTIVAL

John Travolta was surprised with an honorary Palme d'Or at the Cannes Film Festival premiere of his directorial debut on Friday.

Thierry Fremaux, the festival's artistic director, brought out the award for Travolta just before the screening of his 'Propeller One-Way Night Coach'. A visibly moved Travolta clutched his chest while Frémaux presented the trophy.

"You said this would be a special night, but I didn't know it would mean this," Travolta said to Frémaux.

"This is beyond the Oscar!" exclaimed Travolta.

Clad in a white beret, Travolta walked the Cannes red carpet with his 26-year-old daughter, Ella Bleu Travolta. The actor wrote, directed and co-produced 'Propeller One-Way Night Coach', based on his own 1997 children's novel.

Cannes has sometimes previously surprised guests with an honorary Palme d'Or. It unexpectedly gave one to Tom Cruise in 2022. At this year's festival, the 'Lord of the Rings' filmmaker Peter Jackson was given one in the opening ceremony. Barbara Streisand is to receive one later during the festival. AGENCIES

DRISHYAM 3

Hindi & Malayalam versions to have different narratives

MUMBAI: The makers of the hit 'Drishyam' franchise, Abhishek Pathak and Kumar Mangat Pathak, said the upcoming third instalment in Malayalam and Hindi will have distinct narratives, offering audiences different storytelling within the same cinematic universe.

The crime thriller franchise, known for its taut narrative, sharp twists and gripping performances, has over the years garnered a strong and loyal fan base across languages and demographics.

"Both the stories of 'Drishyam 3' in Malayalam and Hindi are going to flow differently. The Malayalam version shifts into an emotional family drama, while the Hindi version will be a drama-thriller. It will be fun to see both versions and notice the changes in it," writer-director of the Hindi film 'Drishyam 3', Abhishek Pathak, told PTI.

'Drishyam' originated as a 2013 Malayalam film starring Mohanlal and its sequel came out in 2022. The third part will hit theatres on May 21. Jeethu Joseph has directed all three movies.

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The success and acclaim of 'Drishyam' led to its remake in several languages, including Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Chinese (Mandarin) and Sinhalese. The Hindi version, directed by the late Nishikant Kamat and headlined by Ajay Devgn, also turned out to be a massive hit, with the first part arriving in 2015. It was followed by the second part, helmed by Abhishek Pathak, in 2022. The filmmaker is also directing 'Drishyam 3', which will come out in cinema halls on October 2.

According to Abhishek, the scripts for the two versions of 'Drishyam 3' were developed independently. "I wrote my story keeping the Hindi audience in mind so that they get what they are expecting from Vijay Salgaonkar (Ajay's character) in the film. Jeethu Joseph wrote his version. Later, we read each other's drafts and we loved both," the writer-director, who has penned the third part with writers Aamil Keeyan Khan and Parveez Shaikh, said.

The third part of 'Drishyam' was in the news a few months ago after the sudden exit of Akshaye Khanna, who played a pivotal role in the second part. The makers then roped in Jaideep Ahlawat for 'Drishyam 3'. PTI

Cult classic 'Amma Ariyan' screened at Cannes Film Festival

NEW DELHI: The cult Malayalam classic 'Amma Ariyan' was showcased in the 'Cannes Classics' section at the Cannes Film Festival in a newly restored 4K version by the Film Heritage Foundation.

Originally released in 1986, the 115-minute-long film is widely considered one of the most radical works in Indian cinema. It was directed by the late John Abraham, known for his politically driven and unconventional storytelling and was his final film before he died in 1987.

The screening took place on Saturday at the festival held in Cannes on the French Riviera in southern France and it was the only Indian title featured in the 'Classics' section.

Produced by the 'Odessa Collective', a group of film enthusiasts cofounded by Abraham, the film is set against the political unrest of 1970s Kerala. It follows Purushan, who sets out to inform a mother about her son's death, gradually gathering companions on a journey that becomes both personal and political.

It was showcased in a newly restored 4K version by the Film Heritage Foundation

The film's 4K restoration, which began in 2023, faced significant challenges due to the lack of quality source material, with only a poor online copy initially available. After locating surviving members of the 'Odessa Collective' and securing their permission, a global search through the International Federation of Film Archives (FIAF) yielded just two 35mm prints at the National Film Archive of India. PTI

COMEDY IS A STAPLE GENRE FOR THE INDIAN AUDIENCE: AYUSHMANN KHURRANA

The actor currently stars in his new film 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do'

MUMBAI: Ayushmann Khurrana said comedy is the bread and butter of Indian cinema and believes his new film 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do' carries forward a beloved franchise that began nearly five decades ago.

The actor, who has fronted many comedies including 'Vicky Donor', 'Badhaai Ho', 'Shubh Mangal Saavdhaan', 'Bareilly Ki Barfi' and 'Dum Laga Ke Haisha', stars in the film alongside Sara Ali Khan, Rakul Preet Singh and Wamiqa Gabbi.

"I think comedy is the bread and butter or the staple genre for Indian audiences. It can never be out of fashion. Every season, there has to be one comedy film. Every year, there has to be one defining comedy film," Khurrana told PTI in an interview.

Directed by Mudassar Aziz, 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do' is a follow-up sequel to the 2019 hit 'Pati Patni Aur Woh', which featured Kartik Aaryan, Bhumi Pednekar and Ananya Panday. The franchise traces its roots to the 1978 classic starring Sanjeev Kumar and Ayushmann said he is delighted to now be part of this cinematic legacy.

'Comedy can never be out of fashion,' says Ayushmann

"We're very fortunate to be a part of this beautiful story. I'm saying beautiful because comedy is the toughest genre. We're glad that we're part of this."

Asked about the challenge of making a comedy film in an era dominated by social media, short-form content and OTT platforms, the actor said a film has a distinct advantage.

"I still think that OTT is mostly flooded with thrillers and stories with dark undertones. And stand-up is also not a family viewing content. This comedy movie is still bright sunshine. I think it outshines or maybe breaks the clutter over there that it's a community viewing film. So 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do' is a classic comedy. And we've been watching these kinds of comedies since time immemorial. And this is one of those. And I hope it'll do really well in theatres. Because it has all the masala of a comedy film for family entertainers," Ayushmann said.

In the movie, the actor features as Prajapati Pandey, a forest officer from Prayagraj, whose seemingly happy married life spirals into chaos and comic misunderstandings after his wife, played by Wamiqa, begins to suspect him of infidelity. Sara plays his college friend Chanchal, while Rakul Preet Singh appears as his office colleague. The ensemble cast also includes Vijay Raaz, Tigmanshu Dhulia, Ayesha Raza Mishra and Vishal Vashishtha in supporting roles. PTI